



UNOFFICIAL · COMMUNITY EDITION · OS 1.40C

Octatrack

MK1

The Reworked Manual

A complete reference, learning path, and field guide for Elektron's eight-track dynamic performance sampler — including hidden features, undocumented behaviour, performance recipes, and visual reference.

EDITION

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Octatrack OS 1.40C

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COLOPHON

A note on this manual

This is an unofficial, community-oriented rework of the Elektron Octatrack MK1 manual. It exists because the official documentation, while accurate, has long been considered one of the steeper hurdles a new owner faces. The Octatrack is one of the deepest sampler-sequencers ever built — and the gap between what it can do and what most owners ever discover is enormous.

This rework consolidates Elektron's official manual (OS 1.40A, December 2020) and the OS 1.40C release notes (January 2024 — the firmware shipping on the final production units) with material drawn from the wider Octatrack community: the Rabid Elephant Master Reference, Merlin's Guide, NoiseTheorem's cheat sheet, and the long-running Elektronauts forum threads where most undocumented behaviour was first surfaced. Source attributions appear at the end of the relevant section.

Nothing in this manual is endorsed by Elektron Music Machines MAV AB. "Octatrack", "Elektron", and related marks belong to their respective holders. This document reproduces no copyrighted text from the official manual; all explanations are written fresh, and short factual quotations (where they appear) are clearly marked.

How to read this manual

The manual is structured in twelve parts, moving from orientation (Parts I–II) through conceptual scaffolding (Part III), then operation (Parts IV–IX), into performance and recipes (Parts X–XI), and finishing with a complete reference (Part XII).

A complete beginner should read Parts I–IV linearly. An owner who has used the machine for some time can skip to Part V (machines), Part VIII (scenes and the crossfader), or Part XI (recipes). The reference appendices, especially the **complete button-combo encyclopedia**, are designed to be browsed independently and printed if useful.

Conventions used

FRONT-PANEL KEYS	Shown as <code>FUNCTION</code> , <code>REC</code> , <code>PLAY</code> . Combinations: <code>FUNCTION</code> + <code>REC</code> means hold the first key while pressing the second.
TRIG KEYS	The 16 step buttons are shown as <code>TRIG 1</code> ... <code>TRIG 16</code> when context-specific, otherwise <code>TRIG</code> .
PARAMETERS	Octatrack parameter names appear in monospace small caps, e.g. <code>PTCH</code> , <code>RLEN</code> , <code>XVOL</code> , mirroring the device screen.
MENU PATHS	Written as <code>PROJECT → SYSTEM → CARD TOOLS → FORMAT</code> .
CALLOUTS	

Orange callouts mark **tips** the official manual omits. Black callouts mark **hidden features**. Red callouts mark **warnings**. Blue callouts mark **notes** on quirks and gotchas.

Sources & acknowledgements

The structural authority for this manual is the official Elektron Octatrack User Manual (OS 1.40A, December 2020) and the OS 1.40C release notes (January 2024). Beyond the official sources, the following community works deserve direct credit:

- **The Rabid Elephant Master Reference** — the most thorough community document of Octatrack workflow lore, hidden behaviour, and edge-case troubleshooting.
- **Merlin's Guide** ("Some Thoughts on Elektron's Octatrack") — for the clearest existing conceptual framing of parts, scenes, and the bank/pattern hierarchy.
- **NoiseTheorem's cheat sheet** — for compact key-combo coverage.
- **The Elektronauts forum**, especially the long-running threads on conditional trigs, FX1 reverb, Pickup machine behaviour, the crossfader transition, and the early-startup test mode.
- **Cuckoo, Dataline (Cenk Sayinli), Mark Mosher, Joseph Miller (Sounds Like Joe), and Tarekith** — for the video-tutorial and written workflow material from which several recipes in Part XI are derived.

Authoring

Compiled and authored by **jordanaftermidnight**. Source files, build scripts, and erratum tracking are maintained on GitHub. Pull requests with corrections, additional recipes, or screen-mock contributions are welcome.

First edition · 2026. Errata and revisions welcomed. This document is licensed for personal use and for non-commercial redistribution provided this colophon and authoring credit are preserved.

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PART I · WELCOME

Chapter 2

The Octatrack philosophy

Before any reference tables or step-by-step recipes, a paragraph or two about what kind of instrument the Octatrack actually is. The conceptual frame matters, because the device's reputation for being "hard" is mostly a reputation for being different.

The Octatrack was released in late 2010. Eight stereo audio tracks. Eight MIDI tracks. Two multi-effect units per audio track. Three LFOs per track and a custom LFO designer. Sixteen scenes mapped to a crossfader. A live-input sampling engine. A pattern sequencer with parameter locks, conditional trigs, and a fill mode. All of it on a 128-by-64 monochrome screen, six anonymous encoders, and a row of sixteen step buttons. No visible labels for most of what it does.

Plenty of other samplers existed in 2010. Plenty of other sequencers, too. What made the Octatrack land — and what still makes it land in a way that nothing quite like it has since — was the assumption underneath the design: that a musician on stage with a laptop, looking at a glowing apple, might prefer to be holding something with knobs. Not as a controller for the laptop. Instead of it.

An instrument, not a tool

The Octatrack is sometimes called the deepest sampler in production. That is arguable. What is less arguable is that it is the deepest sampler that insists you become fluent in it. It rewards memorisation. It rewards practice. It rewards a sustained engagement with its idiosyncrasies in a way most modern instruments — built around quick onboarding and immediate gratification — explicitly avoid.

The Octatrack does not want to be your DAW. It wants to be your instrument. The distinction matters.

— A THING MANY OCTATRACK OWNERS HAVE EVENTUALLY SAID

The Mark Mosher / Cuckoo / Dataline / Ess generation of users converged on roughly the same observation: you do not learn the Octatrack the way you learn a piece of software, by reading its menus end to end. You learn it the way you learn a violin. You build a small vocabulary of motions, you repeat them until they become automatic, and only then do you have any capacity left over to think about what you actually want to play.

For the eight or so years between the Octatrack's release and the Digitakt's, Elektron's user community evolved a body of folklore — workflow recipes, button-combo cheat sheets, hidden behaviours — that the official manual described only thinly, or not at all. Much of this manual exists to bring that folklore inside the covers, where it belongs.

What the Octatrack is good at

Live performance with prepared material.

Loops and stems prepared in advance, sliced and resequenced live, with crossfader-driven scene morphing layered on top. The "play your album backwards as a DJ would, but with parameter modulation" use case.

Sampling and resampling, on stage.

Inputs from a microphone, a synth, another sequencer; live recording into eight buffers; one-shot trigs that capture a moment and play it back the next bar. Internal resampling cascades that turn a single source into multiple processed copies on different tracks.

Multi-effect processing of external gear.

Through machines route external audio into the Octatrack's effect chain, with parameter locks per step. Combined with the Neighbor machine, a single external source can be processed by up to four chained effects with independent automation.

Generative and probabilistic patterns.

Conditional trigs, fill mode, parameter randomisation, the LFO designer. Eurorack-density modulation in a fixed-architecture box, available to anyone who is willing to learn how to address it.

Being the hub of a hardware studio.

Mixing, MIDI sequencing, and clocking other Elektron boxes (or anything with a MIDI port), plus a CUE bus that can act as a second main pair when Studio Mode is enabled.

What the Octatrack is not good at

The Octatrack is not a DAW substitute. It does not do non-destructive arrangement in the way a DAW does. It does not have a piano roll. It does not undo. Its timestretching engine is competent but not transparent. Its onboard storage is a Compact Flash card. Its USB port does mass storage and SysEx, and that is all — there is no Overbridge, no audio over USB, no MIDI over USB.

It is also not a fast machine to compose complete songs on, unless your workflow has already been shaped to fit it. Building a four-minute arrangement from scratch using only the Octatrack's

arranger requires a great deal of forward thinking. Many owners use the arranger sparingly and instead perform their songs live, switching patterns and parts by hand.

A USEFUL FRAME

Treat the Octatrack as the **final mile** of a workflow whose first miles happen elsewhere. Sample design, source recording, and large-scale arrangement are usually faster done in a DAW or on dedicated gear. The Octatrack's contribution is to take that finished material and turn it into something performable, mutable, and alive.

The MK1 in 2026

The Octatrack MK1 has been out of production since 2017, replaced by the MK2. The two units run identical firmware (1.40C is the final release for both), share the same project format, and differ only in hardware: the MK2 has a brighter OLED screen, balanced ¼-inch inputs, contactless crossfader, backlit buttons, and dedicated keys for several functions that on the MK1 are reached by a combo. Everything described in this manual works on both machines unless explicitly noted; where MK1 and MK2 diverge, the MK1 path is given first and the MK2 equivalent is shown in a sidebar.

A working MK1 in 2026 is a fully supported, complete instrument. The 1.40C firmware, released January 2024, is its terminal version — Elektron has confirmed there are no further feature releases planned for the MK1 line. Used units remain plentiful and can usually be had for between half and a third of the MK2's current retail price. The community knowledge base, by now over a decade deep, more than compensates for the absence of new factory documentation.

Everything you need to play this instrument well is in the next twelve parts.

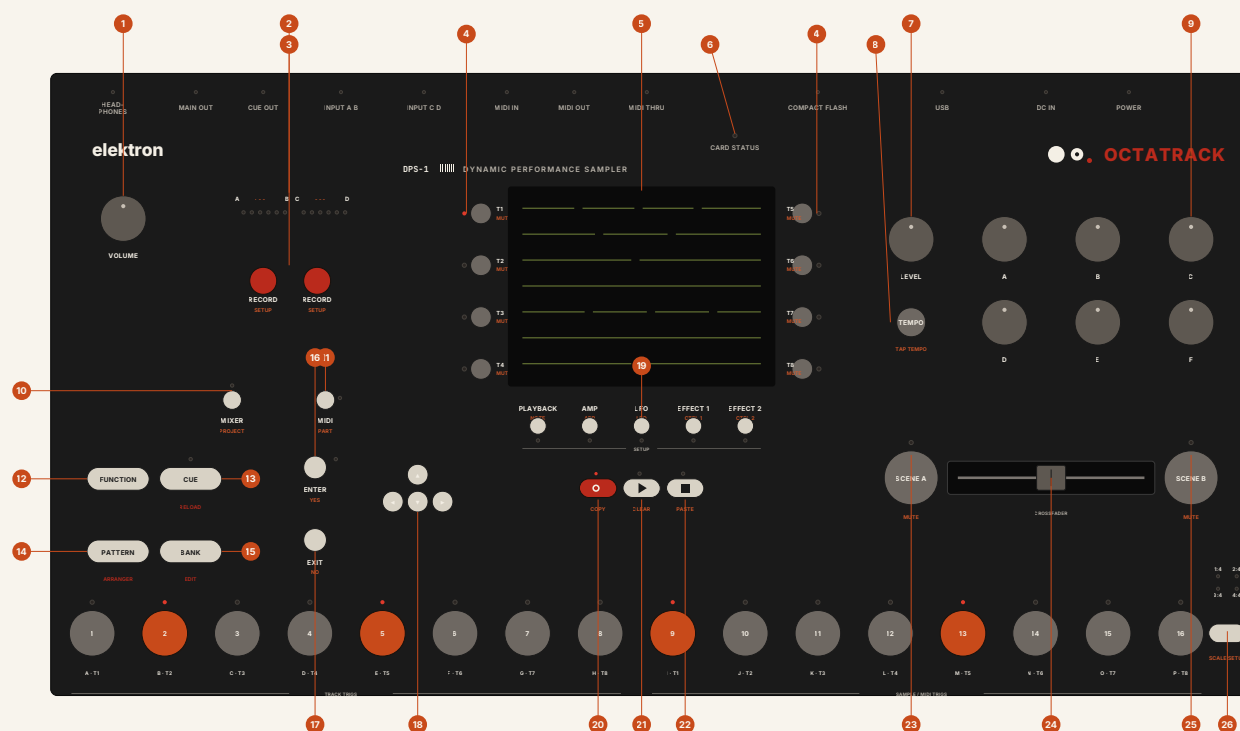
PART II · HARDWARE TOUR

Chapter 4

Top panel anatomy

Every control on the MK1 faceplate, numbered to match the official manual. By the end of this chapter no key on the surface should be unfamiliar.

The diagram below uses the same numbering as the official Octatrack User Manual, OS 1.40A. Numbers 1–9 cover knobs, the LCD, and indicator LEDs. Numbers 10–22 cover the function keys, navigation, parameter row, and transport. Numbers 23–26 cover the scenes, crossfader, and time-signature cluster. The 16 trig keys at the bottom are not individually numbered in the official scheme — they're treated as a single control (the bottom band), with secondary labelling reproduced verbatim.



OCTATRACK - MK1 - TOP PANEL

FIGURE 4.1 Top panel of the Octatrack MK1, schematic. Numbering matches the official OS 1.40A manual, sec. 3.1. Buttons in red (REC AB/CD, transport REC) are red on the actual unit; orange- filled trigs (2 / 5 / 9 / 13) are example active steps.

Knobs, the screen, indicator LEDs (1–9)

1 • Headphones volume control

Top-left knob, marked Volume on the faceplate. Sets the level at the rear-panel headphones jack. On the MK1 it is dedicated to the headphones output and does not affect the main outs — track levels are set in the Mixer page (per-track) and the master output is set with **FUNCTION** + **LEVEL** (callout 7).

2 • Audio Record LEDs (A – B and C – D)

Two horizontal rows of small LEDs to the right of the volume knob, labelled **A – B** and **C – D**. They show the signal strength on the corresponding rear-panel input pair. Pre-fader: they indicate what's arriving at the converters, not what the recording-setup gain stage is doing with it. Use the rightmost (red) LED as a clip indicator and back the source off if it lights on peaks.

A second function: when the Recording Setup menu is open, these LEDs also indicate the source selection for the recorder trigs — a useful confirmation that the recorder is listening to the source you expect.

3 • Audio Record buttons (REC AB / REC CD)

The two large round red buttons. There is one record button per audio input pair: the left one captures pair AB, the right one captures pair CD. Pressed alone (in the standard PERSONALIZE configuration) they begin sampling immediately into the active recorder buffer. With **FUNCTION** they open the corresponding Recording Setup page; with a **TRACK** key held they record into that specific track's recorder.

4 • Track buttons (T1–T8)

The eight small round buttons flanking the LCD: **T1** through **T4** in a column to the left of the screen, **T5** through **T8** in a column to the right. Each has a track-status LED beside it.

The official manual's description, in summary:

- Press a **TRACK** button to **focus** on that track.
- **TRACK** + **AUDIO RECORD** records into that track's recorder.
- **FUNCTION** + **TRACK** mutes the selected track.
- **CUE** + **TRACK** routes the selected track to the cue bus.

The track LEDs show three states simultaneously: which track is the focus, which tracks are muted, and which tracks are routed to cue. Their colour and brightness convey the combination — the full table is in Appendix A's LED-state legend.

5 · LCD

128 × 64 pixel monochrome graphical interface. The MK1's screen is fixed-contrast — there is no backlight intensity control. Cleaning: a microfibre cloth and very mild isopropyl. The display has been observed to develop horizontal banding on units beyond a decade old; this is cosmetic and does not affect function.

The screen divides into three regions: the **title bar** (active track number, mode indicator, transport state, BPM), the **main pane** (large knob arcs and parameter values), and the **label strip** at the bottom (six four-letter parameter labels mapping to data-entry knobs A–F). When a parameter is locked on the active step, the corresponding label inverts.

6 · Card Status LED

A small LED near the top edge of the panel, beside the Compact Flash label. Lights during card activity (read or write). If it stays lit continuously for more than a few seconds without action, the OT is busy with a long save or a scan; do not power-cycle until it returns to dark.

7 · LEVEL

The larger grey knob to the right of the LCD. Sets the overall volume level of the active track (post-FX, pre-crossfader). Its function changes by context:

- Normal play: active-track level.
- **FUNCTION** + **LEVEL** : **main output volume** — the closest thing to a master fader the OT has on the front panel.
- With a **TRIG** held in grid edit: sets the trig's conditional value.
- In TEMPO mode: sets project tempo.

8 · TEMPO

Single button on the right side, between the encoder cluster and the scene controls. Pressed alone it brings up the Tempo menu. The **TEMPO** LED above the button flashes at the current BPM — so even with the menu closed, the panel tells you the tempo at a glance. Tap-tempo: hold **FUNCTION** and tap **TEMPO** repeatedly.

9 · Data-entry knobs (A B C / D E F)

Six endless encoders in a 2×3 grid: **A** **B** **C** in the top row, **D** **E** **F** in the bottom row. Each one edits whichever parameter the LCD's bottom label strip currently assigns to it. Push any knob while turning to scroll in coarse increments — useful for jumping past large value ranges. Pushing without turning is ignored by most pages; a few sub-screens use it as enter.

The function block (10–18)

10 • MIXER

Opens the Mixer menu, where input/output settings, per-track levels, and the cue/solo states are accessed. **FUNCTION** + **MIXER** opens the **Project** menu — the topmost level of the OT's data hierarchy, where you save, load, format, and switch projects.

11 • MIDI

Toggles MIDI editing mode. When the **MIDI** LED is lit, the eight track keys select MIDI tracks rather than audio tracks; the parameter row's labels change to **NOTE**, **ARP**, **LFO**, **CTRL 1**, **CTRL 2**; and the encoders edit MIDI parameters.

When the Recording Setup menu is open, the **MIDI** LED becomes a second-purpose indicator: it shows the signal strength of the internal sample source as well as which internal source is selected for the recorder trigs.

FUNCTION + **MIDI** opens the **Parts** menu. When a Pickup machine is loaded on the active track, the same combination performs a number of Pickup-specific commands (covered in chapter 25).

12 • FUNCTION

The universal modifier. Held with any other key it accesses that key's secondary action.

Secondary labels are printed on the faceplate in red, beneath or beside their primary labels.

Treat **FUNCTION** as the OT's Shift key; once you've memorised twenty or so combos, the panel feels much more compact than it looks.

13 • CUE

CUE + **TRACK** routes that track to the CUE outputs; its primary purpose is headphone pre-listen, with a secondary use as an independent stereo pair when Studio Mode is enabled (see chapter 5, callout 10). **FUNCTION** + **CUE** becomes **RELOAD** — restores the active part's parameters from the saved state, useful as a safety net before destructive edits.

14 • PATTERN

Held alone, turns the trig row into a 16-pattern selector for the active bank. Releasing without pressing a trig dismisses the selector without changing the pattern. **FUNCTION** + **PATTERN** opens the **Arranger**.

15 • BANK

Held alone, turns the trig row into a 16-bank selector (A–P). Each bank holds 16 patterns and 4 parts. **FUNCTION** + **BANK** opens **EDIT** mode — the per-pattern edit menu.

16 · ENTER · YES

Round button beneath the parameter row, with an LED indicator above it. Confirms menu actions. Has a long tail of secondary uses across other contexts: **TRIG** + **YES** previews a step (with all parameter locks) on the MAIN bus; **TRACK PARAM** + **YES** randomises the active page's parameters (an OS 1.40 addition).

17 · EXIT · NO

Round button beneath ENTER. Cancels menu actions, exits sub-screens. Mirrors the secondary actions of YES with the inverse semantic: **TRACK PARAM** + **NO** reloads the active page's parameters from the saved part — together with YES it functions as a per-page A/B comparison. **FUNCTION** + **NO** erases parameter locks at the playhead during live record.

18 · Arrow keys

Cluster of four small round buttons in a + arrangement: ▲ ▼ ◀ ▶. Cursor navigation in menus, parameter scaling on some pages, and sequencer page-turn (LEFT and RIGHT cycle through the four pages of a 64-step pattern). With **FUNCTION**: LEFT and RIGHT shift trigs left or right within the page — a quick way to reorganise a beat without redrawing it.

Parameter row, transport (19–22)

19 · Parameter pages

Five rectangular buttons in a row above the transport. Each one selects a parameter page that the data-entry knobs A–F then edit. On audio tracks: **PLAYBACK**, **AMP**, **LFO**, **EFFECT 1**, **EFFECT 2**. On MIDI tracks (with the MIDI LED lit): **NOTE**, **ARP**, **LFO**, **CTRL 1**, **CTRL 2**.

The **SETUP** band beneath the row indicates the secondary state: holding **FUNCTION** while pressing any of these five opens that page's setup screen — where, for example, you assign which sample slot a track plays from, or which effect occupies the FX2 slot.

20 · COPY (REC)

The transport **REC** button. Primary function: arms recording into the sequencer. **REC** + **PLAY** enters live-record mode; adding **FUNCTION** enters quantised live-record. Secondary function (with **FUNCTION**): **COPY** — the universal copy-to-clipboard operator, contextual to whatever is currently held (steps, patterns, parts, scenes, samples, slots).

21 · CLEAR (PLAY)

The transport **PLAY** button. Primary function: starts and stops the sequencer. Secondary function: **CLEAR** — the universal clear/empty operator, contextual to whatever is held. **FUNCTION** + **PLAY** additionally resets the sequencer to step 1 before starting.

22 · PASTE (STOP)

The transport **STOP** button. Stops the sequencer; pressed twice in quick succession also silences any active reverb and delay tails immediately. Secondary function: **PASTE** — the universal paste-from-clipboard operator. Together, the Copy/Clear/Paste triad is the OT's standard editing toolkit.

Scenes, crossfader, scale (23–26)

23 · SCENE A · MUTE

Round button at the lower-right area, to the left of the crossfader. Held alone, it turns the trig row into a 16-scene selector for assigning which scene the A end of the crossfader maps to. Note that SCENE A is an assigner, not a switcher — it sets which scene the fader's A end controls; it does not jump scenes. With **FUNCTION** it becomes **MUTE** for its assigned scene — useful for instant bypass without moving the fader.

24 · CROSSFADER

The horizontal slider between the two scene buttons. Morphs between the two scenes assigned to its A and B ends. Every parameter on the device that supports a scene lock can be morphed by it.

On MK1 the crossfader is an optical sensor riding a mechanical track; on MK2 it is contactless. The mechanical nature of MK1's fader means it can develop dust-related crackle over time — curable with a careful disassembly and a clean (covered in Appendix G's troubleshooting tree).

NOTE · THE CROSSFADER'S ACTUAL BEHAVIOUR

Newcomers often expect the crossfader to behave like a DJ-mixer crossfader — fading between two stems on its A and B ends. The Octatrack's fader does not work that way. It morphs between two **parameter snapshots**; whether those snapshots correspond to "two different mixes" depends entirely on what you locked into Scene A and Scene B.

25 · SCENE B · MUTE

Mirror of Scene A on the right side of the crossfader. Assigns which scene the fader's B end maps to. With **FUNCTION**: mute Scene B.

26 · SCALE SETUP

Small button at the far right with four LEDs (**1:4** **2:4** **3:4** **4:4**) above it indicating the current step's relationship to the master scale. Held alone (or pressed) it opens the per-track length, master length, and time-scale settings — covered in chapter 17.

The play surface — 16 trig keys

The bottom row of the panel is sixteen large round buttons numbered 1–16, each with an LED above it and a dual label below: a letter (A–P) and a track number (T1–T8, repeated twice across the row). Trigs 1–8 are grouped under **Track Trigs**; trigs 9–16 under **Sample / MIDI Trigs**.

Their primary function depends on the active trig mode (chapter 18):

- **TRACKS mode** — drop sequencer trigs on the active track's pattern.
- **CHROMATIC** — play the active sample at twelve different pitches across the row.
- **SLICES** — trigger the active sample's slice points (up to 64 slices, paged across the trig row).
- **SLOTS** — switch the active track's sample slot.
- **QUICK MUTE** — instant per-track mute toggling.
- **DELAY CONTROL** — temporary delay-send modulator.

The letters A–P are referenced when **BANK** is held (each bank is named by its letter); the track numbers T1–T8 are used in MIDI mode for direct track addressing from external keyboards.

Backlighting and labelling on MK1 vs MK2

The MK1's keys are not individually backlit — only the per-track and per-trig LEDs above the buttons illuminate. Secondary functions (the **FUNCTION** +key actions) are silkscreen-printed in red on the faceplate, in small type, and are quite easy to miss. The button-combo encyclopedia in Appendix A reproduces every label; photocopying that appendix and keeping it next to the unit while you learn is a perfectly reasonable thing to do.

The MK2 adds a separate row of dedicated track-select keys, an **ARR** button, a **PROJ** button, an **AED** button (audio editor), a **MIX** button, and a third record button (**REC 3**) that captures internal sources directly. On MK1 each of these is reached by a combination of the buttons described above; the relevant combos are noted at the start of each chapter where they apply.

PART II · HARDWARE TOUR

Chapter 5

Rear panel & connections

Twelve connector groups along the back edge. Numbering matches sec. 3.2 of the official OS 1.40A manual.

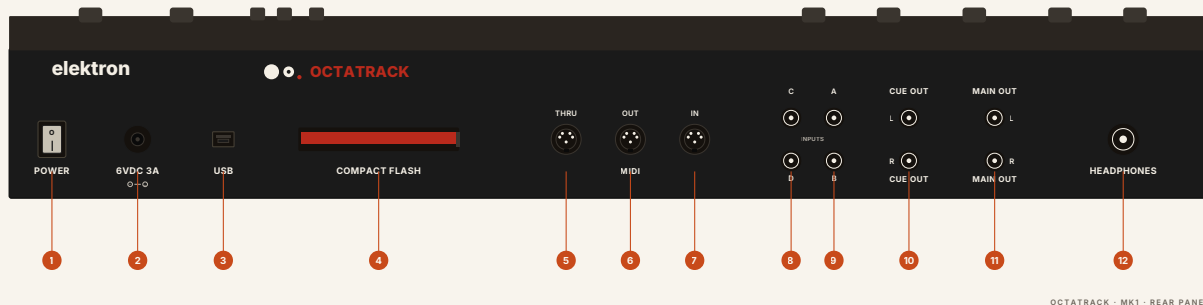


FIGURE 5.1 Rear panel of the Octatrack MK1, schematic. Numbering matches the official OS 1.40A manual, sec. 3.2.

1 • Power on / off

Rocker switch. Always stop the sequencer and save your project before powering down — the Octatrack does not commit unsaved RAM-resident recordings to the CF card on power loss. Power-cycling while a save is in progress can also corrupt the project file.

2 • 6V DC power in

Centre-positive 6 V / 3 A barrel jack — the  symbol next to the jack confirms the polarity. Use the original Elektron PSU or a high-quality replacement matching the polarity and current rating. Underspecified supplies cause intermittent reboots, especially on busy projects.

3 • Hi-Speed USB 2.0

Two functions only: **mass storage** for accessing the Compact Flash card from a host computer (PROJECT → SYSTEM → USB DISK MODE), and **SysEx transport** for OS upgrades and backup dumps. There is no USB MIDI, no USB audio, and no Overbridge — the port has never carried audio in either direction, on either MK1 or MK2.

4 • Compact Flash card reader

Type I CF slot. The MK1 was originally tested up to 4 GB; with the OS 1.30+ filesystem improvements, cards up to 64 GB work reliably. Use FAT32. Avoid SD-to-CF adapters in long-term use — many introduce write failures the OT silently tolerates until a save corrupts. Genuine industrial CF cards (SanDisk Extreme, Lexar Professional 1066x or higher) remain available and worth the purchase.

5 • MIDI Thru

5-pin DIN. Echoes incoming MIDI from the IN port without re-quantising or modifying it.

6 • MIDI Out

5-pin DIN. Sends data from the OT's eight MIDI tracks plus clock, transport, and SysEx.

Supports Elektron's **TurboMIDI** protocol — higher-than-standard baud rates between two Elektron boxes for faster CC streams. Anything connected, Elektron or otherwise, falls back to standard MIDI baud automatically.

7 • MIDI In

5-pin DIN. Receives clock, notes, CCs, NRPNs, and SysEx. Used for slaving the OT to an external clock, for triggering audio tracks from a keyboard, and for receiving real-time controller data into the eight MIDI tracks.

8 • Input C / D

Two ¼" jacks forming the **CD pair**. C is the top jack (left channel), D is the bottom jack (right channel). On MK1 the inputs are **unbalanced** at +8 dBu peak. (The MK2 changed this to impedance-balanced inputs at +17 dBu, a 9 dB headroom improvement that is the single most-cited reason to prefer MK2 for studio use.)

9 • Input A / B

Two ¼" jacks forming the **AB pair**. A is the top jack (left channel), B is the bottom jack (right channel). Same electrical characteristics as the CD pair. Together with CD, these provide four mono input channels arranged as two stereo pairs.

10 • Cue Out L / R

Stacked vertical pair (L on top, R on bottom). Impedance- balanced ¼". By default the CUE bus carries whatever tracks are currently routed to it via **CUE** + **TRACK** — useful for headphone pre-listen. With **Studio Mode** enabled (PROJECT → CTRL → AUDIO → OUTPUTS = STUDIO) the CUE bus becomes a completely independent main pair: each track gets a MAIN volume and a CUE volume, and the two pairs can carry different mixes for front-of-house and stage monitoring, or for a hardware mixer return.

11 • Main Out L / R

Stacked vertical pair (L on top, R on bottom), to the right of Cue Out. Impedance-balanced

¼". Carries the sum of all tracks routed to MAIN, after the master track's FX if a Master machine is loaded on T8.

12 • Headphones output

Single ¼" stereo jack at the right edge. Driven by the front-panel headphones-volume knob (callout 1 in chapter 4). Mirrors the CUE bus by default; mirrors the MAIN pair when the CUE bus is empty and Studio Mode is off.

WARNING · GROUND HUM ON UNBALANCED INPUTS

The MK1's unbalanced inputs are susceptible to ground loops when the Octatrack and a connected synth or mixer are on different mains circuits. If you hear 50/60 Hz hum that disappears when you unplug the source, you have a ground loop. The right fix is a properly grounded power distribution; a serviceable temporary fix is a transformer-isolated DI box on the offending source.

A small note on the chassis

The MK1's enclosure is silver-painted steel with the rear panel forming a structural chassis. Two screws on each side and a row along the rear edge open the unit. Inside, three ribbon cables connect the upper UI PCB to the main board — significant if you ever need to service the crossfader or a failed encoder. The MK2 uses two ribbons and a slightly different geometry; service docs from MK2 do not all transfer.

Battery: a CR2450 lithium-manganese cell, retained in a clip on the main PCB. It backs up RAM-held pattern and part data so the unit boots into the project it was last working on without a full CF reload — Elektron quotes a six-year shelf life under typical use. When the battery fails, the Octatrack will still work, but every cold start will take longer and any unsaved work in RAM will be lost. Replacement is straightforward and detailed in Appendix G.

PART III · MENTAL MODEL

Chapter 6

The data hierarchy

Sets, projects, banks, patterns, parts. The Octatrack's data structure is the single most important thing to understand before you touch a sequencer page — and the source of most newcomer confusion.

The Octatrack does not have a "song" or a "preset". It has a layered structure where data lives at five different scopes: the **card**, the **set**, the **project**, the **bank**, and the **pattern/part**. Knowing which scope a piece of data belongs to is how you avoid the two most common Octatrack disasters: losing work, and accidentally overwriting something elsewhere on the machine.

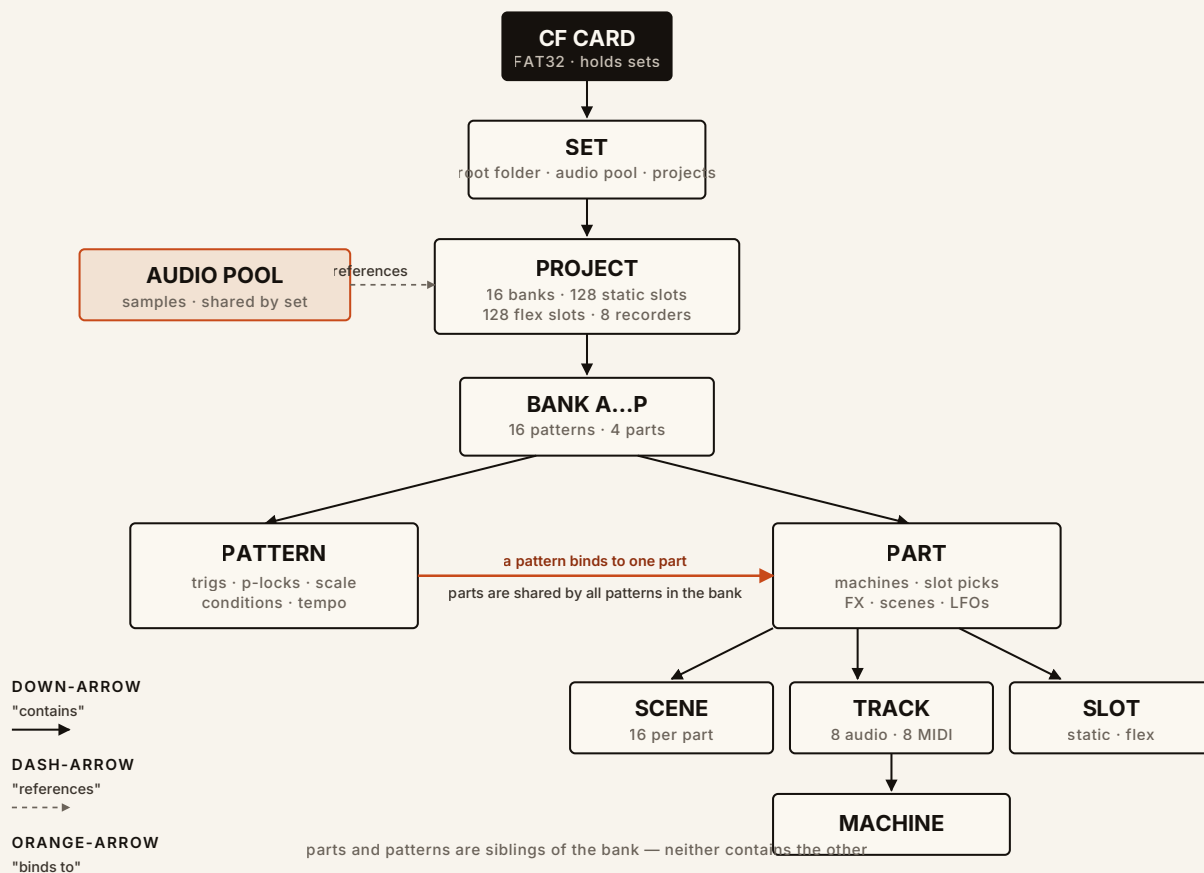


FIGURE 6.1 The Octatrack's nested data scopes. Each level inherits the level above and is overridden only at save time.

Card

The Compact Flash card is the root of everything. Format it FAT32 and the Octatrack creates a top-level folder structure on first boot. A single card can hold dozens of sets, each one a self-contained workspace. Cards are interchangeable — taking one out and inserting another is how you switch between, say, a live-set CF and a studio-experiments CF without having to manage projects within a single card.

Set

A set is a folder on the card. It contains an **Audio Pool** (the shared sample library, see chapter 7) and one or more **projects**. The set is the boundary between which samples a project can see — projects within the same set share the Audio Pool; projects in different sets do not.

Practical use of sets: one set per album, one per gig, one per studio session. The Audio Pool grows over time within a set; starting a fresh set keeps things tidy.

Project

The project is the "song" container, though the metaphor is loose. It holds:

- **16 banks** (A–P), each containing 16 patterns and 4 parts
- **Project-wide settings** — sync source, MIDI config, audio routing, memory configuration
- The **Arranger** — up to 8 arrangements per project, chaining patterns into long-form structures
- References to samples in the Audio Pool, plus per-project **sample slots** (Static + Flex slot lists)

Loading a project loads all of the above into RAM. Saving a project writes the current RAM state back to the card. **Unsaved changes are lost on power-off** — the OT does not auto-save.

Bank

A bank is 16 patterns plus 4 parts, identified by a letter A–P. Banks are independent: switching from bank A to bank B replaces the patterns and parts in active memory. Banks A–P are accessed by holding **BANK** and pressing the corresponding trig key.

The 4 parts within a bank are shared across that bank's 16 patterns. Any pattern can be assigned to any of the 4 parts — a pattern's "instrument set" comes from its assigned part.

Pattern

A pattern is the sequence: the trigs, parameter locks, microtiming offsets, conditional trigs, and per-track pattern length. Patterns are 1 to 64 steps, with per-track lengths possible for polyrhythmic sequences.

A pattern references a part — it does not contain the instrument data itself. Two patterns assigned to the same part will play through the same set of machines and samples; changing the part affects both.

Part

The part is the instrument container. It holds:

- Per-track **machine assignments** (Static, Flex, Thru, Neighbor, Pickup, Master)
- Per-track **sample slot assignments** (which sample each Flex/Static track plays)
- Per-track **parameter base values** for all five pages (PLAYBACK, AMP, LFO, FX1, FX2)
- Per-track **scene assignments** for both ends of the crossfader
- Per-track **MIDI track data** (channel, port, base note, etc.)

A pattern + its part = the complete musical statement at that moment. Saving a part is separate from saving a pattern, and worth doing whenever you've made changes you want to keep.

WARNING · THE UNSAVED-PART PROBLEM

The most common Octatrack frustration: making careful per-track adjustments, switching to a different pattern, returning to the original — and finding all the adjustments wiped. The cause is almost always an **unsaved part**. Patterns hold their changes in RAM, but switching parts reloads the part from disk if the in-memory copy hasn't been saved. **FUNCTION** + **YES** on the part page commits the part to disk; do this often.

What lives where — a cheat sheet

DATA	SCOPE	SAVED WITH
Sample audio file	Audio Pool (set)	Card
Sample slot list	Project	Project
Machine on track 1	Part	Part
PLAYBACK page values	Part	Part
Scene assignments	Part	Part
Trigs on a step	Pattern	Pattern
Parameter locks	Pattern	Pattern
Pattern length	Pattern	Pattern
Tempo	Project (or pattern, optionally)	Project
MIDI sync source	Project	Project

Memorising this table saves hours of debugging. When something "sticks" or "won't stick", the answer is almost always at the part or project level — not the pattern.

PART III · MENTAL MODEL

Chapter 7

Audio Pool, Static, Flex

How samples physically exist on the Octatrack — where they live on disk, when they load into RAM, and the difference between Static and Flex memory. Get this right and the rest of the machine makes sense.

Audio Pool

Every sample available to a project lives in the **Audio Pool** — a folder on the CF card, scoped to the current set. The Audio Pool is just files: WAV or AIFF, mono or stereo, 16-bit or 24-bit, at any sample rate up to 96 kHz. The Octatrack will resample on load if needed; for cleanest playback, normalise to 44.1 or 48 kHz beforehand.

Samples are referenced from the project, not embedded in it. Deleting a sample from the Audio Pool while a project references it produces an error message (and a silent track) on next load. The Octatrack does not "save with project" the way a DAW does — your project file is small (a few KB); the audio lives separately in the Pool.

Maximum samples per Audio Pool: 999. Practical limit: card speed and your patience while it indexes.

Static slots vs Flex slots

A project holds **two parallel sample-slot lists**: 128 Static slots and 128 Flex slots. A track loaded with a Static machine plays from the Static list; a Flex track plays from the Flex list. The two lists are independent — slot 1 in Static and slot 1 in Flex are different samples (or empty).

The slot list is a project-level construct. It maps a slot number to a file in the Audio Pool, plus per-slot trim points (start/end loop points), gain, and BPM info.

The fundamental difference: where the audio lives

Static

Audio for a Static slot is **streamed from the CF card** on demand. The Octatrack reads the file as the playhead moves through it. RAM usage is essentially zero. Disk-streaming has constraints:

- Cannot reverse-play (no random-access fast enough)
- Cannot pitch significantly down (slows playback past disk-read speed)
- Limited to the file's natural length and direction

Best for: long files (full songs, stems, loops over a few seconds), backing tracks, anything where the file plays linearly once at a time.

Flex

Audio for a Flex slot is **loaded into RAM** on project load. RAM usage is the file size — a 30-second 44.1 kHz stereo WAV is about 5 MB. With the OT's RAM split between Flex and other pools (configured via Memory Config), you can hold roughly 80 MB of Flex samples by default.

- Reverse-play, pitch up/down, scrubbing — all instant
- Slice playback — instant jump to slice points
- Real-time time-stretch (TIMESTRETCH page)

Best for: drum hits, one-shots, short loops, anything that needs playback flexibility, anything you want to slice.

Memory configuration

The Octatrack's RAM is partitioned at the project level via PROJECT → MEMORY CONFIG. The total available is fixed; you choose how to split it between:

- **Flex sample memory** — your Flex slots
- **Recorder memory** — capacity of the eight recorder buffers (one per audio track), in mono seconds, in stereo seconds, and at 24-bit or 16-bit
- **Reserve** — what's left for the OS

The default split is balanced for general use. If you need long recording buffers (multi-bar live capture), reduce Flex memory and increase recorder memory. If you need many short Flex samples, reverse the trade.

NOTE · MEMORY CONFIG REQUIRES REBOOT

Changing Memory Config doesn't take effect until the project is saved and reloaded. The OT prompts you for this. Don't change Memory Config mid-performance.

When does loading happen?

On project load, the OT reads the slot lists and:

- Scans the Audio Pool for each referenced file
- Loads every Flex slot's audio into RAM
- Indexes each Static slot's file (does not load the audio)

A project with 50 small Flex samples loads in seconds. A project with a hundred multi-megabyte Flex samples can take 30–60 seconds. The Card Status LED on the front panel indicates load activity.

Practical workflow

RECIPE — CHOOSING STATIC OR FLEX

Quick decision tree:

1. Sample longer than 30 seconds and plays linearly? → **Static**
2. Need to slice it, reverse it, time-stretch it, or pitch it significantly? → **Flex**
3. It's a drum hit, one-shot, or short loop? → **Flex**
4. It's a backing track, full-length stem, or DJ source? → **Static**
5. Both? Load it as both — Static and Flex slots are independent, and many performances assign the same audio file to both lists for different uses.

The Sample Manager

PROJECT → SAMPLE MANAGER opens the unified file browser for the Audio Pool. From here you assign samples to slots, audition them, set per-slot trim points, view file metadata, and clean up unused samples.

The Sample Manager also manages the file-system view of the Audio Pool: rename, move between sub-folders, delete, batch-load. For detailed Audio Pool management workflows, see chapter 27.

PART III · MENTAL MODEL

Chapter 8

Eight tracks, master, signal flow

How audio actually moves through the Octatrack. The signal path is simple in outline and becomes powerful through the combinatorics of what each track can do.

Eight audio tracks

The Octatrack has eight audio tracks, T1 through T8. Each track holds one machine — a chunk of sample-playback or audio-routing logic — and processes that machine's output through a fixed signal chain: **PLAYBACK** → **AMP** → **FX1** → **FX2** → mixer routing.

All eight tracks are equal in capability except T8, which has a special role: when its assigned machine is the Master machine, T8 becomes a master-bus processor (chapter 16). Otherwise T8 is a normal audio track.

Alongside the audio tracks is a parallel set of **eight MIDI tracks**. MIDI tracks share the same trig keys when MIDI mode is active (chapter 11 of Part IX); they don't process audio.

Per-track signal chain

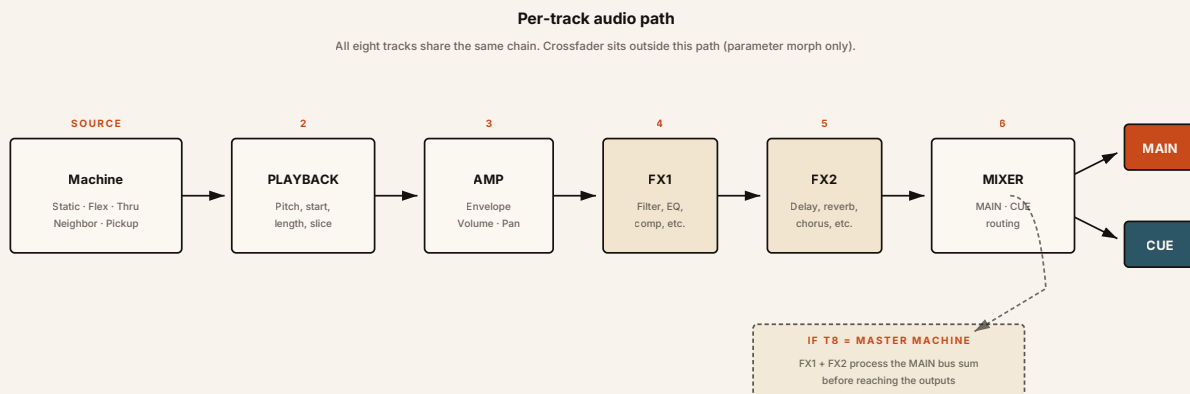


FIGURE 8.1 Audio path for a single track. The crossfader is not in this chain — it modulates parameters on this chain, not audio.

1. Source

The track's machine produces audio. For Static and Flex machines, this is the active sample slot's audio, played at the position determined by current trigs and parameter locks. For Thru machines it's the live audio from a chosen rear-panel input pair. For Pickup machines it's the contents of that track's recorder buffer.

2. PLAYBACK page

Pitch, sample start, length, loop, time-stretching, slice selection. These shape what portion of the source plays and how. See chapter 21.

3. AMP page

Amplitude envelope (attack, hold, release), volume, balance (pan). Every Octatrack track has an AMP envelope; a flat envelope is just "track plays at full volume". See chapter 22.

4. FX1, FX2

Two effect slots per track. Each slot can hold any one of the available effects (filter, EQ, delay, reverb, chorus, compressor, phaser, lo-fi, etc.). FX1 runs before FX2; the order is fixed. Choosing which effect lives in each slot is done on the FX page's Setup screen.

5. Mixer routing

After FX2, the track's audio is routed to one or more of:

- **MAIN bus** — the master stereo output
- **CUE bus** — pre-listen / Studio Mode second pair
- Both, with independent levels

Routing is set on the Mixer page. The MAIN bus is summed across all eight tracks; if T8 is loaded with a Master machine, that sum runs through T8's PLAYBACK / AMP / FX1 / FX2 chain before reaching the rear-panel MAIN outputs.

The Master track quirk

When T8's machine is set to Master, T8 stops being a normal track and becomes a master-bus effects insert. Its sample slot is ignored; its trigs are ignored; its sequencer page does nothing audible. What it does have is its FX1 and FX2 slots, which now process the entire MAIN-bus sum.

This is how you get a master EQ or master compressor on the Octatrack: load the Master machine on T8, then put a Compressor on its FX1 and a final EQ on its FX2. Note that you lose T8 as a sound-producing track when you do this — eight becomes seven.

The crossfader is not in the chain

The crossfader morphs parameter values between two snapshots (Scene A and Scene B). It does not gate audio or sit in any signal path. When you move the fader, every parameter that has a scene lock interpolates between the A value and the B value. The audio signal flow above is the same whether the fader is at A, at B, or anywhere between.

A useful corollary: if you scene-lock a track's level to 0 at Scene A and to maximum at Scene B, the fader will appear to fade that track in or out. But the audio still flows through the same chain — the level parameter is what's changing.

What this means in practice

With one machine per track, you build composite voices through routing (Neighbor machines that read the previous track's output — see chapter 16) or by parallel arrangement (drum loop on T1, bass on T2, atmosphere on T3, etc.). Eight tracks is more than it sounds when each track has its own two effect slots, its own LFO, and full parameter-lock control per step.

TIP · THE FX1/FX2 ORDERING HACK

Because FX1 always runs before FX2, the choice of which effect goes where matters. A reverb on FX1 followed by a filter on FX2 sounds very different from filter→reverb. When you find a combination that doesn't sound right, try swapping the slots before swapping the effects.

PART IV · THE SEQUENCER

Chapter 9

Trigs & parameter locks

The Octatrack sequencer's two atomic concepts. Everything else — microtiming, conditional trigs, fill mode, scenes — is built on these.

The trig

A **trig** is a step in the pattern that fires the track's sound. The trig row at the bottom of the panel (in TRACKS mode) shows 16 trigs at a time; the pattern's full length, up to 64 steps, is paged across the four pages with the LEFT/RIGHT arrow keys.

To add a trig: press a trig key while the corresponding track is selected. The trig key lights, and the trig will fire on that step every time the pattern reaches it. To remove: press the trig key again. To preview a trig (with its locks) without committing it, hold **YES** + the trig key.

Trig types — pressed in the same way but distinguished by held modifiers:

- **Note trig** — the default. Fires the sample at the trig's pitch and parameter values.
- **Trigless lock** — held **FUNCTION** + trig. Records parameter locks at this step but does not re-trigger the sample. Useful for parameter automation that rides over a sustained note.
- **One-shot trig** — held **YES** + trig. Fires once when armed (typically used with the Pickup machine), then disarms itself.
- **Hold trig** — long-press a trig in Live Record mode while a sound plays.

The parameter lock

A parameter lock ("p-lock") records a parameter value specifically for one step. When the pattern reaches that step, the parameter takes the locked value; on every other step, it uses the part's base value.

To set a p-lock:

1. Hold the trig key for the step you want to modify
2. While holding, turn any data-entry knob (A-F) — the value moves for that step alone
3. Release the trig key

The trig now has a parameter lock, indicated by a red light on the trig and an inverted parameter label on the LCD when that step is selected. To clear all locks on a step: hold the trig and press **NO**. To clear locks on a single parameter: hold the trig and press the parameter knob (A–F) corresponding to it.

P-locks work on every parameter the OT exposes — pitch, sample start, slice number, filter cutoff, FX values, even the sample slot itself (a sample slot lock, see chapter 21). This is the OT's signature feature: any single step can sound radically different from any other.

P-lock examples

RECIPE — PITCH LADDER

Place a kick drum sample on every step of a 16-step pattern. Hold step 5 and turn the pitch knob down 5 semitones; hold step 13 and turn it up 7 semitones. The pattern now plays the kick at three distinct pitches across the bar — at the same loudness, same envelope, same FX. One sample, one pattern, three voices.

RECIPE — MOVING FILTER SWEEP

With a sustained pad sample on a track, place 16 trigs (one per step) and lock the FX1 filter cutoff at gradually higher values across the pattern. You've drawn a filter envelope without using an LFO — and it's editable on a per-step basis.

Trigless locks

A trigless lock changes parameters without re-triggering the sound. To set: hold **FUNCTION** + trig key, then turn knobs.

Why this matters: if a sample plays for several steps after its initial trig (long release, sustained loop), p-locking subsequent steps would re-trigger the sample. Trigless locks let you ride parameters over the sustain — a filter sweep on a long pad, a pitch bend on a sustained note, an FX wet/dry change without interrupting the sound.

On the trig row, trigless locks show a different LED state from note trigs. The full LED-state legend is in Appendix A.

The base value vs. the locked value

Every parameter has a **base value** set on the parameter page (the knob position you see in the LCD when no trig is held). Locks are deltas from this base: at every unlocked step, the parameter uses the base; at locked steps, it uses the lock.

Adjusting the base value changes every unlocked step. This is the fastest way to "shift everything" — turn the base knob, all unlocked steps follow; locked steps stay where you put them.

TIP · THE SILENT-STEP TRICK

Want to make a track go silent for a few steps without removing its trigs? P-lock the AMP track-volume to zero on those steps. The trigs still fire, the sample still plays, but at zero level — so when you raise the volume p-lock back up later, the trigs are still there waiting.

The scope reminder

Trigs and p-locks live in the **pattern** (chapter 6). Switching to a different pattern presents a different set of trigs/p-locks — the part stays the same. This is why two patterns on the same part can sound radically different: the part defines the instrument, but the pattern's trigs and locks define the performance.

PART IV · THE SEQUENCER

Chapter 10

Microtiming & conditional trigs

Two features that lift the Octatrack sequencer above the step-quantised grid — microtiming pushes trigs off the grid; conditional trigs make trigs probabilistic or context-dependent.

Microtiming

By default, every trig fires exactly on its step's beat division. Microtiming offsets a single trig forward or backward in time by a fraction of a step — adding push, pull, swing, or human inconsistency to a single hit.

To set microtiming: hold the trig key, then press the LEFT or RIGHT arrow key. Each press shifts the trig by 1/23rd of a step. The OT shows the offset on the LCD as a small numeric value (negative = earlier, positive = later).

Microtiming range is roughly $\pm$ half a step. Pushing further wraps around (a "+12" trig on step 5 fires earlier than the next step's natural time, but not earlier than step 5 itself).

Practical uses

- **Swing** — add positive microtiming to every other step. Common values: +5 to +10 for subtle swing, +12 to +18 for broken-beat feel.
- **Drag and push** — pull the snare back ~3 ticks for a laid-back feel; push the hi-hat forward 2–4 for urgency.
- **Humanisation** — randomise small amounts (± 2 to ± 5) across an otherwise rigid pattern.
- **Polyrhythmic phasing** — combined with per-track pattern lengths, microtiming creates complex evolving textures.

Conditional trigs

A conditional trig only fires if a condition is met. Conditions are set per-trig via the LEVEL knob while a trig is held. As you turn LEVEL with a trig held, the LCD displays the active condition.

The OS 1.40A condition list, in order:

CONDITION	MEANING
FILL	Fires only when fill mode is active
FILL (inverted)	Fires only when fill mode is NOT active
PRE	Fires if the previous trig on this track fired
PRE (inverted)	Fires if the previous trig did NOT fire
NEI	Fires if the same step on the neighbouring (lower-numbered) track fired
NEI (inverted)	Fires if the neighbouring track step did NOT fire
1ST	Fires only on the first cycle of the pattern
1ST (inverted)	Fires on every cycle EXCEPT the first
X%	Probability — fires X% of the time (10, 20, ... 90%)
A:B	Fires on the A-th occurrence out of every B (e.g. 1:2 = every other; 2:3 = the second of every three)

Using conditions

The most useful conditions in practice:

- **FILL** — keep fills off the main pattern; they only appear when you trigger fill mode.
- **50%** — the workhorse. Add probabilistic hi-hat flutters, ghost snare hits, occasional accents.
- **1:2** — alternates between hits on even/odd cycles, useful for variations.
- **PRE** — chains. A trig with PRE only fires if the previous step's trig also fired — useful for ratchet-style repeats.
- **NEI** — couples tracks. A trig on T2 with condition **NEI** only fires if T1's same-step trig fired. Useful for accent layers tied to a kick.

RECIPE — PROBABILITY CASCADE FOR HI-HATS

On a 16-step pattern, place a hi-hat trig on every step. Set conditions:

- Steps 1, 5, 9, 13: no condition (always fire — the downbeats)
- Steps 3, 7, 11, 15: 80% (steady upbeats with occasional dropouts)
- Steps 2, 6, 10, 14: 50% (off-beats that come and go)
- Steps 4, 8, 12, 16: 30% (rare flourishes)

The hi-hat now feels alive — different on every cycle, but the core groove (1, 5, 9, 13) is rock-solid.

Fill mode

Fill mode is a momentary switch that activates all **FILL**-conditional trigs. Activate with **FUNCTION** + **YES** (toggle), or hold **FUNCTION** + **YES** for momentary (release ends the fill).

The classic use: design the main groove without fills, then add a parallel layer of FILL-conditional trigs that only fire when you momentarily activate fill mode. Ride the fill switch during a performance to introduce variation without changing patterns.

Inverted-FILL trigs fire only when fill is off — useful for "drop the kick during the fill" effects. Combine FILL and inverted-FILL on the same pattern for clean swap-outs.

Combining conditions

Each trig has one condition. To stack effects, use multiple trigs on adjacent steps with different conditions, or use per-track pattern lengths to create longer-evolving sequences.

The combination of microtiming + conditional trigs + parameter locks is what makes the Octatrack's sequencer feel generative rather than mechanical. Two patterns, one part, careful use of conditions: indistinguishable from improvisation in many contexts.

HIDDEN · NEI CONDITION PITFALL

The NEI condition references the previous track (e.g. T2's NEI condition checks T1; T3 checks T2). It does NOT chain across all tracks. T1's NEI references T8, wrapping around. A common mistake is expecting NEI on T5 to depend on T1; it depends on T4. Plan track ordering accordingly.

PART IV · THE SEQUENCER

Chapter 11

Trig modes

The 16 trig keys do six different jobs depending on the active trig mode. Switching modes is the difference between drawing a sequence, playing a chromatic scale, triggering slices, or muting tracks live.

Switching modes

Hold **FUNCTION** and press the UP/DOWN arrow keys to cycle through trig modes. The current mode is shown in the LCD title bar.

The six modes:

1. TRACKS mode (default)

Each trig key represents a step in the active track's pattern. Pressing a trig adds or removes that step. This is the "draw the sequence" mode you spend most of your time in.

Sub-behaviours:

- **TRIG** alone — toggle step on/off
- **TRIG** hold — set p-locks, microtiming, conditions
- **FUNCTION** + **TRIG** — trigless lock
- **YES** + **TRIG** — preview the step (with locks)
- **CUE** + **TRIG** — preview to the CUE bus

2. CHROMATIC mode

The 16 trig keys become a one-octave keyboard. Pressing a trig plays the active sample at a corresponding pitch — trig 1 = root note, trig 2 = root+1 semitone, and so on. Trig 13 is the octave; trigs 14–16 extend three semitones into the next octave.

Useful for:

- Playing pitched samples (bass, leads, single-cycle waveforms)
- Live sample-pitching during performance

- Pattern composition by recording chromatic input into Live Record (chapter 12)

The base pitch is the sample's natural pitch as set on the PLAYBACK page. Octave shifting is via **FUNCTION** +UP/DOWN within CHROMATIC mode (not the trig-mode switcher — UP/DOWN alone shift octaves once you're in CHROMATIC).

3. SLICES mode

Each trig key plays a different slice of the active sample. Available with Flex machines that have a slice grid defined (chapter 30 — audio editor SLICE page).

Trig 1 plays slice 1, trig 2 plays slice 2, etc. The OT supports up to 64 slices per sample, displayed across four pages (LEFT/RIGHT arrows page through the slice ranges). The current page is shown on the LCD.

Use cases:

- Beat slicing — chop a drum loop into 8 or 16 slices, play any permutation
- Vocal cutting — slice a phrase into syllables, retrigger any in any order
- Build new patterns by slicing and recording slice trigs into Live Record

4. SLOTS mode

Each trig key selects a different sample slot for the active track. Trig 1 = slot 1, trig 2 = slot 2, etc.

SLOTS mode is fast for switching between samples during performance or for recording slot changes into Live Record (giving a track that plays a different sample on each step).

Combined with the sample slot lock (chapter 21), SLOTS mode is how you build pattern-driven sample variation without multiple tracks.

5. QUICK MUTE mode

Each trig key toggles mute for one of the eight tracks. Trigs 1–8 correspond to tracks 1–8; trigs 9–16 are inactive.

QUICK MUTE is a performance mode for live arrangement-building — drop tracks in and out without using **FUNCTION** +TRACK combinations. It's the fastest way to mute multiple tracks simultaneously (just slap multiple trigs).

A muted track in QUICK MUTE shows on the trig row as a dim LED; unmuted tracks show as bright LEDs.

6. DELAY CONTROL mode

The most performance-oriented mode. Each trig key, when held, momentarily sends the active track's audio through a delay effect at a different feedback amount and time setting per trig. Release the trig and the effect goes back to its base value.

The default mapping:

- Trigs 1–4: increasing delay time, low feedback
- Trigs 5–8: medium delay, medium feedback
- Trigs 9–12: longer delay, more feedback
- Trigs 13–16: extreme settings (long, near-self-oscillating)

DELAY CONTROL is configured per project; the exact mapping is editable. It's the OT's answer to "instant delay throw" without needing to scene-lock or p-lock — just hold a trig.

TIP · DELAY CONTROL WITH FX2 REVERB

Because DELAY CONTROL momentarily routes through the delay, pairing it with a reverb on FX2 produces "delay-into-reverb" throws that decay naturally when you release the trig. The result is dub-style throws without parameter-lock setup.

Mode persistence

Trig mode is a per-track state. Switching tracks does not change the mode. Switching projects resets to TRACKS mode.

The most common mistake: forgetting you're in CHROMATIC or SLICES mode and trying to add trigs to a pattern. The trigs play sound but don't write to the pattern. Always check the LCD title bar.

PART IV · THE SEQUENCER

Chapter 12

Live record & preview

Real-time pattern entry and the audition workflow. Two complementary modes: live record captures performance into the sequencer; preview auditions trigs without committing them.

Live Record

Live Record lets you record trigs and parameter changes while the sequencer plays. Two flavours:

Unquantised Live Record

Activate: hold **REC** + **PLAY**. The OT enters Live Record mode (REC LED flashing). Any trig key you press is recorded at the exact moment it occurs — including its microtiming offset relative to the nearest step.

Use case: live, expressive entry where exact timing matters. Pressing trigs slightly behind the beat creates lay-back; ahead of the beat creates push. Useful for finger-drumming and chromatic melodic input.

Quantised Live Record

Activate: hold **FUNCTION** + **REC** + **PLAY**. Any trig you press is snapped to the nearest step. Microtiming is zeroed.

Use case: tighter, more rigid recording — useful when capturing chromatic input and you want clean step-aligned trigs.

What gets recorded

- Trig presses (TRACKS mode) — added as note trigs at their timing
- Trig presses (CHROMATIC mode) — recorded as note trigs with pitch p-locks
- Trig presses (SLICES mode) — recorded with slice-number p-locks
- Knob movements — recorded as p-locks on the step the playhead passes through
- Sample slot changes (SLOTS mode) — recorded as slot p-locks

Erasing on the fly

Hold **FUNCTION** + **NO** while the sequencer plays in Live Record. Any step the playhead passes through is erased — both the trig and any p-locks on it. Release to stop erasing.

This is the OT's "moving rubber" — useful for quickly clearing a section of the pattern without exiting Live Record.

Preview

Preview lets you hear what a step would sound like (with its p-locks) without committing to it.

Two preview destinations:

- **YES** + **TRIG** — preview to MAIN bus
- **CUE** + **TRIG** — preview to CUE bus (headphone pre-listen)

Both forms play the trig's sample with the trig's parameter locks applied. Use case: while building a pattern, audition each step's locked values before deciding whether to keep them.

Pattern length and per-track length

Pattern length is configured per pattern via **FUNCTION** + **SCALE SETUP**. The OT supports patterns from 1 to 64 steps.

Per-track length: each track can have its own pattern length within the master pattern. This creates polymeter — track 1 loops at 16 steps while track 2 loops at 13 steps, drifting in and out of phase.

Master length sets the overall pattern duration; track lengths are capped at master. When a track's length is shorter than master, the track repeats internally until master cycles.

Time scale

The time scale (1/4, 1/8, 1/16, 1/32) determines how fast the sequencer runs through its steps relative to the project tempo. Default 1/16 — each step is a sixteenth note. Change to 1/32 for fast hi-hat or trap-style sequences; 1/8 for half-time feels.

Time scale is per-track. A 1/32 hi-hat track on a 1/16 master pattern fires twice as fast — but loops twice within the same master cycle, so the timing aligns musically.

The 1:4 / 2:4 / 3:4 / 4:4 LEDs

The four LEDs above the Scale Setup button (callout 26 in chapter 4) flash on each beat of the master pattern, showing your position within the bar. They're a visual metronome — useful for live performance when you can't take your eyes off the panel.

Recording knobs and parameter changes

In Live Record, knob movements are recorded as parameter locks on every step the playhead passes through during the move. Move a filter knob through one cycle of the pattern, and you've drawn an automation curve into the sequencer.

The recorded automation can be edited per-step afterwards — hold a trig to see the locked value, turn the knob to adjust. Combined with Live Record's trig entry, this is how complex evolving patterns get built on the OT in minutes rather than hours.

TIP · STOP WITH SEQUENCER PLAYING

To exit Live Record without stopping the sequencer, press **REC** alone. This disarms recording but keeps playback running. Useful for iterative composition: enter Live Record, add some trigs, exit to listen, re-enter to add more.

PART V · MACHINES

Chapter 13

Static & Flex machines

The two principal playback machines. Static streams from the card; Flex plays from RAM. Almost every Octatrack project uses both.

Static machine

Loads from the Static slot list. Plays the slot's audio file by streaming from the CF card.
Constraints: forward playback only at moderate pitch ranges; cannot reverse; cannot pitch-shift below about -12 semitones without artefacts.

Page parameters

PAGE	ENCODER A	B	C	D	E	F
PLAYBACK	Slot	Pitch	Start	Length	Loop	Rate
AMP	Atk	Hold	Rel	Vol	Bal	Xvol

Best for

- Backing tracks (full songs, stems)
- Long ambient samples
- DJ workflows where each track is a complete song
- Anything over 30 seconds where RAM would be wasted

Flex machine

Loads from the Flex slot list. Audio is in RAM. Supports the full range of OT playback: reverse, pitch shift over a wide range, slice playback, scrubbing, time-stretching.

Page parameters (Flex-specific)

The Flex machine has the same PLAYBACK page layout as Static, plus these additional capabilities:

- **Negative pitch** at **PTCH** -64 = octave down (full speed reverse capable)
- **Reverse** via **RATE** negative values, or via the reverse trig

- **Slice mode** via **START** set to slice number (0–63) when slice grid exists
- **Time-stretch** on the TIMESTRETCH page (only on Flex; chapter 30)

The TIMESTRETCH page

Flex tracks have access to a TIMESTRETCH page (accessed by holding **FUNCTION** + the LFO button). It allows:

- **NORM** — pitch and tempo bound together (changing rate changes both)
- **BEAT** — tempo follows project tempo, pitch independent (the standard "stretchy" mode)
- **OFF** — pitch and rate decoupled, no stretching

BEAT mode is the standard time-stretch behaviour: the sample auto-conforms to project tempo, and you can pitch it independently. Quality is acceptable for moderate stretches; extreme stretches introduce artifacts (which can themselves be musical).

Choosing between Static and Flex

Quick guide:

NEED	STATIC	FLEX
Sample ≤ 30s, drum hits, loops, vocals		✓
Backing track, full song, stem	✓	
Need to slice		✓
Need reverse playback		✓
Time-stretching		✓
Pitch shift > 1 octave		✓
RAM is full	✓	

A common pattern: one or two Static tracks for backing material, five or six Flex tracks for everything else. The Master machine on T8 if you need master-bus FX. This is the canonical "live Octatrack" project layout.

Sample slot locks

Both machines support sample slot locks — a parameter lock that swaps the sample slot for a single step. Hold a trig, turn encoder A (the SLOT parameter), and the trig now plays a different slot from the slot list.

This is the Octatrack's "kit-switching per step" capability. With 16 trigs and 16 different slot locks, one track can play 16 different drum sounds across a bar — using only one slot list and one machine.

TIP · SLOT-LOCK FOR KIT DRUMMING

Build a slot list of drum hits (kick, snare, hat, clap, perc, etc.). On a single Flex track, place 16 trigs and slot-lock each to a different drum. You've built a one-track drum kit that takes no extra tracks. Combined with pitch p-locks per step you can get surprisingly varied drums from a single track.

Slot setup workflow

1. **FUNCTION** + **PLAYBACK** opens the Setup screen for the active track's machine
2. Encoder A scrolls through slots; encoder B previews
3. **YES** assigns the highlighted slot to the track
4. **EXIT** returns to the **PLAYBACK** page

Slots can be loaded from the Sample Manager if not already assigned. The Setup screen shows the current slot, file name, and estimated memory usage.

PART V · MACHINES

Chapter 14

Thru, Neighbor & Master machines

Three machines that don't play samples. Thru passes external audio through; Neighbor reads the previous track's signal; Master turns a track into a master-bus processor.

Thru machine

A Thru machine routes external audio (from one of the rear-panel input pairs) directly into the track's signal chain. The track becomes a live audio processor — your synth or external source runs through the OT's PLAYBACK, AMP, FX1, and FX2.

Thru-machine PLAYBACK page has different parameters: source selection (AB, CD, A, B, C, D), input gain, balance.

Use cases

- Treat the OT as a multi-effects unit for your synth
- Apply scenes/p-locks to live input — modulate the FX on external sound through the crossfader
- Use a Thru-machine track as a "drone layer" running an external oscillator through the OT's filter and reverb

A Thru track does not have a sample, but you can still place trigs on it — they'll just have no audible effect (no sample to play). The trigs can carry parameter locks, however, which means you can sequence FX changes on the Thru-track's input without the input itself being sequenced.

Neighbor machine

A Neighbor machine reads the audio output of the previous track (T2's neighbor is T1's output, T3's neighbor is T2's, etc.). It feeds that audio into its own signal chain — meaning T2's PLAYBACK /AMP/FX1/FX2 process T1's output.

This creates serial effect chains. T1 plays a sample; T2 (Neighbor) adds a delay; T3 (Neighbor of T2) adds a reverb. Each track contributes one effects pair, but the audio cascades.

Why this matters

The Octatrack normally limits you to 2 effects per track. With Neighbor machines you can stack effects across multiple tracks — 4, 6, even 8 effects in series.

Cost: each Neighbor track consumes a track slot. If you want T1 with a 6-effect chain, you'll spend T1, T2, T3 on the chain. The upside is full p-lock control over each effect stage independently.

Wraparound

T1's neighbor is T8 — the chain wraps. This is rarely useful but occasionally produces feedback paths if used carelessly (e.g. placing T8 as Master with T1 as Neighbor of T8 creates a feedback loop). The OT prevents true feedback through Neighbor, but the wraparound is real.

TIP · NEIGHBOR FOR PARALLEL PROCESSING

Place the same sample on T1 and a Neighbor on T2. The two tracks now play the sample with independent FX chains. Mix them on the mixer page for parallel processing — wet/dry blends, frequency splits, etc. T1 = clean, T2 = filtered + delayed. Or T2 muted, crossfader-controlled to fade in.

Master machine

Loaded only on T8. Turns T8 into a master-bus processor: T8's sample slot is ignored, T8's trigs are silent, but T8's FX1 and FX2 process the entire MAIN bus sum (the mix of T1 through T7, plus any tracks routed to MAIN).

T8's Master configuration:

- FX1 — typically a Compressor or EQ for master-bus glue
- FX2 — typically a final EQ, limiter, or Lo-Fi for character
- AMP volume on T8 — acts as master output volume

What you lose

You lose T8 as an audio-producing track. Eight tracks becomes seven. For most projects this is a fair trade for master-bus FX. For projects already at 7-track capacity, consider whether master FX are worth the dedicated slot.

What you gain

- Master compression for unified loudness across the mix
- Master EQ for tonal correction
- Lo-fi or saturation for character ("OT mix glue")
- Scene control over master parameters — fade out the entire mix via a scene-locked AMP volume

Choosing your machine layout

A few canonical setups:

Studio mix layout

- T1–T6: Static and Flex playback (drums, bass, leads, etc.)
- T7: spare Flex track for live capture
- T8: Master machine

Live performance layout

- T1: Pickup machine — live looper
- T2–T6: Flex playback for sequenced material
- T7: Thru machine — external synth input
- T8: Master

Effects-rack layout

- T1: Thru machine — input
- T2–T7: Neighbor chain — six stages of effects
- T8: Master

These are starting points. The OT rewards experimenting with machine assignments — a project's layout is part of its sound design.

PART V · MACHINES

Chapter 15

Pickup machine

The Octatrack's live looper. Pickup is the trickiest machine to learn — its state model is unfamiliar — but once internalised it's the OT's most powerful performance tool.

What Pickup does

A Pickup machine records audio (from a chosen input or internal source) into its own internal buffer, then plays back what it captured. It's a looper: capture, then loop.

Pickup's distinguishing feature is its tempo-locked behaviour. Unlike a generic looper that captures whatever length you press for, Pickup quantises capture and playback to the project's bar/beat grid. This is what makes it useful in sequence-based performance: the loop you capture fits into the rest of your patterns.

Master and Slave Pickups

Pickup machines come in two flavours, set per track on the Setup page:

- **Master Pickup** — the first Pickup loop in a project. Sets the loop length for all subsequent Pickup loops in the same project.
- **Slave Pickup** — every Pickup track after the first. Locks to the master's length; allows multi-track looping with synchronised lengths.

Typical use: T1 = Master Pickup, T2/T3 = Slave Pickups. Recording on T1 sets the bar count for everything; T2 and T3 capture loops of identical length, layered.

The state machine

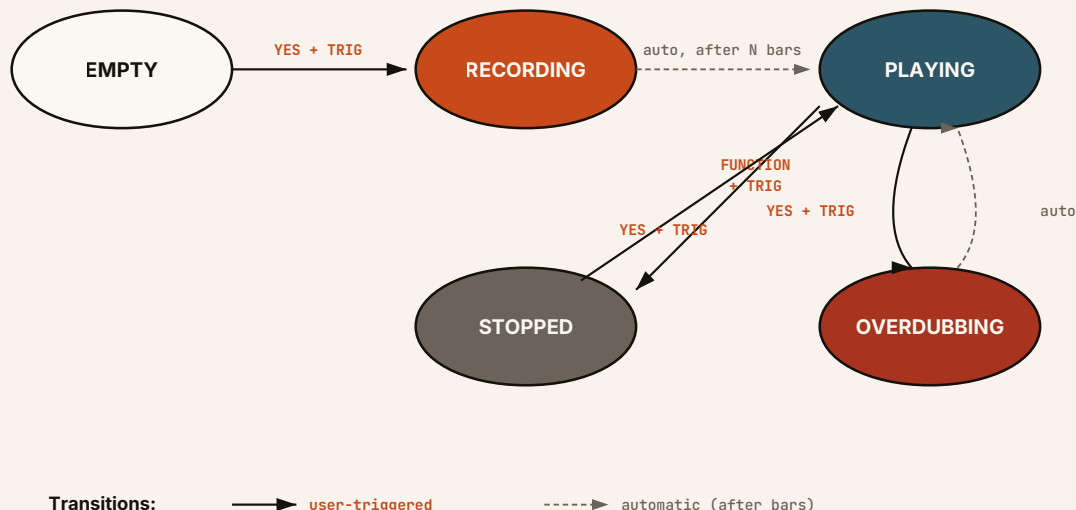


FIGURE 15.1 Pickup's playback states. Transitions are triggered by the one-shot trig (Yes + trig) or by scene changes.

Pickup tracks are always in one of these states:

- **EMPTY** — no audio captured. Track is silent.
- **RECORDING** — capturing audio into the buffer. Track plays back the audio currently being recorded (overdub possible).
- **PLAYING** — looping the captured audio.
- **STOPPED** — buffer holds audio but track is silent.
- **OVERDUBBING** — playing AND recording over the existing loop (additive layering).

Triggering Pickup

Pickup's trigs are one-shot trigs: they fire once and then disarm. Set with **YES** + trig key. When the sequencer reaches a one-shot trig on a Pickup track, it triggers the next state transition:

- **EMPTY** → **RECORDING**
- **RECORDING** → **PLAYING** (after the bar count completes)
- **PLAYING** → **OVERDUBBING** (next one-shot)
- **OVERDUBBING** → **PLAYING**
- **STOPPED** → **PLAYING**
- **PLAYING** → **STOPPED** (**FUNCTION** + one-shot)

The sequence isn't entirely automatic — the next one-shot determines what happens next. With careful pattern design, you can sequence a series of state transitions across a long pattern.

Pickup recording length

The bar count (loop length) is set by the master Pickup track. The options:

- 1 bar, 2 bars, 4 bars, 8 bars, 16 bars (preset values)
- "Inf" — record until you press stop, then quantise to the nearest bar

Slave Pickups always capture the master's length. If the master is set to 4 bars, every slave records exactly 4 bars even if you press the trigger early.

Source selection

Pickup records from a chosen source, set on the Setup page:

- Input AB or CD — record live external audio
- The MAIN bus (post-mixer) — record the OT's full mix
- The CUE bus — record a curated sub-mix
- One specific track's output — capture just that track

Recording from MAIN or CUE creates resampling-style loopers — the OT records its own output back onto a track, layered with whatever you played live.

FUNCTION combinations on Pickup

With a Pickup machine on the active track, several **FUNCTION** +key combinations gain Pickup-specific behaviour:

- **FUNCTION** + **MIDI** (PART) — opens Pickup-specific options
- **FUNCTION** + one-shot trig — clear and re-arm that trig
- **FUNCTION** + **STOP** — stop all Pickup tracks immediately

Performance recipes

RECIPE — BASIC LOOPER

1. Load a Pickup machine on T1, set as Master, source = Input AB, length = 4 bars.
2. Plug a microphone or instrument into rear input AB.
3. Place a one-shot trig on step 1 of T1's pattern.
4. Press play. T1 records 4 bars of input. After 4 bars it enters PLAYING and loops.

5. Place another one-shot trig on a later step. When the sequencer hits it, T1 enters OVERDUB. Play more, the layer adds. After 4 bars it's back in PLAYING.

RECIPE — MULTI-TRACK STACKING

With T1 as Master and T2/T3 as Slaves, you can layer three independent loops at the same bar length. Each track captures and plays independently — record bass on T1, melody on T2, ambient drone on T3, all at 4 bars, all looping in sync.

HIDDEN · RESAMPLING TRICKS

Set Pickup's source to MAIN bus and place trigs that capture the OT's own output. Effectively this samples the live mix — including all current FX, scene morphs, and other tracks' audio. Record 4 bars of an evolving scene, then loop and modulate with filter/pitch p-locks. The "OT sampling itself" workflow is one of the deepest performance techniques on the machine.

PART VI · SOUND SHAPING

Chapter 16

PLAYBACK & AMP pages

The first two parameter pages: PLAYBACK shapes how the sample plays; AMP shapes its envelope and level.

PLAYBACK page

The PLAYBACK page exposes six parameters. For Static and Flex machines they're broadly equivalent, with Flex offering a wider range on several:

KNOB	PARAM	RANGE	FUNCTION
A	SLOT	0–127	Sample slot for this track
B	PTCH	±64 (Flex), ±24 (Static)	Pitch in semitones
C	STRT	0–127 / slice	Sample start point (or slice number)
D	LEN	0–127	Length of playback from start point
E	RATE	±64	Playback rate (negative = reverse on Flex)
F	LOOP	OFF / ON	Loop the playback within the start/length window

Pitch and rate together

Pitch and rate are independent on Flex tracks (with TIMESTRETCH on) but coupled on Static. For Static, changing pitch changes rate (you're slowing the file down, which lowers pitch). For Flex with TIMESTRETCH off, same coupling. With TIMESTRETCH on, you can pitch without time-shifting, or vice versa.

Sample start, length, loop

These three define the playback window within the sample:

- **STRT** = 0 plays from the file's beginning
- **LEN** = max plays the full length of the file from **STRT**
- **LOOP ON** loops the start/length window indefinitely (until the next trig or until the AMP envelope releases)

P-locking STRT per step is the technique behind glitch and stutter effects: 16 trigs on a sample, each with a different STRT lock, plays 16 different fragments of the file as a sliced loop.

Slice mode

When a Flex sample has a slice grid defined (chapter 30), STRT becomes a slice number selector instead of a position. P-locking STRT then chooses which slice each step plays.

SLICES trig mode (chapter 11) automatically locks STRT to the trig number's slice — but you can also do it manually via p-locks in TRACKS mode.

AMP page

The AMP page shapes the track's amplitude envelope and overall level:

KNOB	PARAM	RANGE	FUNCTION
A	ATK	0–127	Attack time
B	HOLD	0–128	Hold time at full level (128 = infinite)
C	REL	0–128	Release time
D	VOL	0–127	Track output level
E	BAL	±64	Stereo balance (pan)
F	XVOL	0–127 / ±127	Crossfader-controlled volume offset (see chapter 23)

The envelope shape

The OT's amplitude envelope is AHR (Attack-Hold-Release). No sustain stage — HOLD substitutes for sustain by holding peak level for a fixed duration before releasing.

HOLD = 128 means infinite hold — the envelope reaches peak and stays there until a new trig fires (or the track is muted, or something else interrupts). This is the OT's "sustain" mode.

Relationship to sample length

The envelope and the sample's natural length are independent. A short envelope on a long sample cuts the sample short; a long envelope on a short sample lets the sample play through and then holds silence (with potential filter/FX tails) for the remaining envelope time.

XVOL — the crossfader-controlled level

XVOL is a level offset that responds to the crossfader. With XVOL set to a positive value and the fader in scene-locked positions, the track's effective volume becomes $VOL + (XVOL \times \text{fader_position})$.

The mechanism is more deeply useful with scenes — see chapter 23 for the full crossfader integration. For now: XVOL is the parameter you scene-lock when you want the crossfader to fade a track in or out.

NOTE · THE XVOL TRAP

XVOL multiplies with VOL. A track with VOL = 0 cannot be brought up by XVOL — XVOL of any value $\times$ VOL of 0 = 0. To use XVOL for "fade in", set VOL to a non-zero value first, then scene-lock XVOL across the fader. Or use scene-lock on VOL directly. This is one of the OT's most-encountered "why doesn't this work?" issues.

Practical AMP page recipes

RECIPE — KICK STAB

ATK = 0, HOLD = 4, REL = 12. Short, percussive, no tail. Good for short-sample drums and bass stabs.

RECIPE — PAD SWELL

ATK = 30, HOLD = 0, REL = 50. Slow attack, gradual release. The sample fades in and gently fades out — useful for ambient pads from a long sample.

RECIPE — SUSTAINED DRONE

ATK = 0, HOLD = 128, REL = 0. The envelope holds infinitely. One trig produces continuous sound until something interrupts. Use with LOOP ON on PLAYBACK for true sustain.

PART VI · SOUND SHAPING

Chapter 17

LFOs & the LFO designer

Three LFOs per track, plus a full custom-shape designer.
The Octatrack's LFO system is one of the most flexible in any hardware sampler — once you find the designer.

Three LFOs per track

Every audio track has three independent LFOs. Each one can target almost any parameter the track exposes — pitch, filter cutoff, FX parameters, even sample slot.

The LFO page (button to the right of AMP) shows all three at once:

KNOB	PARAM	FUNCTION
A	SPD	Speed (rate)
B	MULT	Speed multiplier (sync to bars/steps)
C	FAD	Fade-in / fade-out time
D	DEST	Destination parameter
E	WAVE	Waveform (sine, tri, saw, square, exp, ramp, random, custom)
F	DEPTH	Modulation depth (positive or negative)

Switching between LFO 1, 2, 3

Use the UP/DOWN arrow keys (within the LFO page) to switch between the three LFOs. The LCD title bar shows which is active.

SPD vs MULT

SPD sets the raw rate; MULT modifies it to align with musical divisions. $MULT \times SPD = \text{effective rate}$. Common MULT values:

- MULT = 1 — free-running, SPD is the rate
- MULT = 32, 16, 8, 4 — bar-synced (full bar, half, quarter, eighth)
- MULT = 64, 128 — multi-bar cycles

Trig modes

LFOs can be set to:

- **FREE** — runs continuously, ignores trigs
- **TRIG** — restarts on every trig
- **HOLD** — runs while a trig is active, holds at last value when released
- **ONE** — fires once per trig and stops
- **HALF** — fires for half a cycle per trig

TRIG mode is the default. ONE is useful for envelope-like LFOs — e.g. a sawtooth ramping down once per trig acts as a decay envelope.

LFO designer (custom waveforms)

Hold **FUNCTION** + **LFO** to enter the LFO designer. Here you can draw custom waveforms with up to 16 points per cycle.

How the designer works

- The screen shows a 16-step horizontal grid
- Each step has a value (the LFO's amplitude at that point)
- Move the cursor with LEFT/RIGHT arrows; adjust the value with knob A or UP/DOWN
- Set INTERP between points (knob B) — linear interpolation, smooth curves, or step-quantised
- Press **YES** to save the custom shape; the LFO can then select it via the WAVE parameter

Why custom LFO shapes matter

Built-in waveforms (sine, square, etc.) cover basic modulation. Custom shapes unlock:

- **Step-locked sequences** — a 16-step LFO with each step at a different value becomes a CV sequence in software form
- **Drum-machine-style accents** — a 16-step LFO modulating volume with peaks every 4 steps
- **Rhythmic filter sweeps** — uneven sweep curves that drum patterns can lock to
- **Pseudo-arpeggiators** — a 16-step LFO on pitch cycling through scale degrees

The interpolation modes

- **LIN** — linear interpolation between points (creates ramps)
- **EXP** — exponential curves (smoother, "musical" feel)
- **S/H** — step-quantised (no interpolation, creates stepped sequences)

LFO destinations

The DEST parameter sets which parameter the LFO modulates. Almost every parameter on PLAYBACK, AMP, FX1, and FX2 is available. Some common targets:

- **PLAYBACK STRT** — random sample-start jumps (with random LFO)
- **FX1 cutoff** — classic auto-wah
- **FX2 delay time** — pitch-warping delay
- **AMP VOL** — tremolo
- **SLOT** — sample-slot rotation (random LFO cycles through slots)

LFOs combined with p-locks

LFOs are part-level (set on the part) but can be p-locked per step. A step can lock LFO speed, depth, or destination — effectively retriggering a different LFO behaviour for one trig.

Combined with conditional trigs and step-locked LFO restarts, the OT's modulation system is closer to a generative-music engine than a static synth: same pattern, different sound every cycle.

HIDDEN · LFO AS ENVELOPE

Set LFO1 to ONE trig mode, MULT = 1, SPD adjusted to taste, WAVE = exp ramp down, DEPTH = positive. Target a parameter and the LFO becomes a one-shot decay envelope. The OT's LFO system can substitute for a second amplitude envelope, a pitch envelope, or a filter envelope — none of which the unit officially has.

PART VI · SOUND SHAPING

Chapter 18

Effects (FX1 & FX2)

The full catalogue of Octatrack effects, plus the famous FX1 reverb hack — a workaround that turns FX1 into a reverb slot despite its limited official choices.

Effect slots

Each track has FX1 and FX2 slots. FX1 runs first; FX2 runs after. The choice of which effect lives in each slot is set on the FX page's Setup screen (**FUNCTION** + **EFFECT 1** or **EFFECT 2**).

FX1 effects

EFFECT	USE
Filter (LP/HP/BP)	Frequency shaping, classic filter sweeps
EQ	Tonal correction, 3-band parametric
DJ EQ	3-band kill-EQ for live use
Phaser	Sweep modulation, 4-stage phaser
Flanger	Short-delay modulation, jet-style swirl
Chorus	Multi-voice ensemble effect
Compressor	Dynamic range control
Lo-Fi	Bit-crusher, sample-rate reducer, distortion
Spatializer	Stereo-width manipulation

FX2 effects

EFFECT	USE
Reverb (Plate)	Plate-style reverb, the OT's main reverb
Reverb (Spring)	Spring-tank-style reverb
Delay	Stereo delay with feedback and modulation
Dark Reverb	Diffuse, low-frequency-emphasised reverb
Comb Filter	Tuned resonant comb filter
Filter (LP/HP/BP)	Same filter family as FX1
Lo-Fi	Same Lo-Fi as FX1, useful for post-reverb destruction
EQ	Final tonal shaping

Note that FX1 and FX2 have different — but partly overlapping — catalogs. Filter, EQ, and Lo-Fi appear on both. Reverb and delay are FX2-only.

FX page parameters

Each effect exposes six parameters mapped to encoders A–F. The specific parameters depend on the chosen effect. A few examples:

Filter (FX1 or FX2)

A	Freq (cutoff)
B	Reso (resonance)
C	Type (LP / HP / BP)
D	Slope (12/24 dB)
E	Drive (input saturation)
F	Mix (wet/dry — usually 100% on FX1)

Plate Reverb (FX2)

A	Time (decay length)
B	Damp (high-frequency damping)
C	Pre-delay
D	Diffusion
E	Low cut
F	Mix (wet/dry)

Delay (FX2)

A	Time
B	Feedback
C	Spread (stereo)
D	Modulation depth
E	Modulation rate
F	Mix (wet/dry)

The FX1 reverb hack

Officially, reverb is FX2-only. But because FX1 has a Spatializer that includes a short ambience component, and because Lo-Fi can be pushed into a degraded near-reverb texture, it's possible to get reverb-like behaviour from FX1 — freeing FX2 for a separate use.

The cleaner method, however: use a Neighbor machine on the next track. Track 1 has FX1 + FX2 (e.g. filter + delay). Track 2 is a Neighbor reading T1's output, with FX1 = filter and FX2 = reverb. Now you have effectively four effects on T1's audio path. The "reverb hack" is mostly historical — the Neighbor approach is more flexible and is documented in chapter 14.

FX setup conventions

Common combinations:

- **Filter + Reverb** — most versatile, classic sample chain
- **Compressor + Delay** — compressed source into delay, useful for vocals or punchy melodics
- **Lo-Fi + Reverb** — degraded character into space
- **EQ + Compressor** (on a Master machine) — master-bus glue
- **Phaser + Delay** — psychedelic textures, swirl + space

P-locking FX parameters

Every FX parameter can be p-locked. This is where the OT's effects become sequenceable: a delay's feedback can rise and fall across a pattern, a reverb's mix can fade in for two bars, a filter's cutoff can sweep on every step.

Combined with LFO modulation (chapter 17) on the same parameters, you can stack rhythmic FX changes (p-locks) over continuous modulation (LFOs) for performative complexity.

TIP · THE WET/DRY PARAMETER (F)

Most effects' Mix parameter is on encoder F. P-locking F to 0 on certain steps disables the effect for those trigs only — useful for "this kick has reverb, this kick doesn't" effects without muting the FX globally.

PART VII · SAMPLING & THE AUDIO EDITOR

Chapter 19

Recording setup

The Octatrack samples on the fly into eight per-track recorder buffers. This chapter covers how to configure recording — sources, lengths, formats — and how the recorder interacts with the sequencer.

The recorder buffers

Every audio track has its own recorder buffer. There are eight buffers total, one per track. They share a common pool of memory (set in PROJECT → MEMORY CONFIG, see chapter 7).

Each buffer can be:

- Triggered by REC AB / REC CD on the front panel
- Triggered by a sequencer record-trig
- Played back as a sample by any Static or Flex track that references it
- Saved to the Audio Pool as a permanent sample (the "Save Recording" option)

Recording Setup pages

Two setup pages, accessed via:

- **FUNCTION** + REC AB — page 1
- **FUNCTION** + REC CD — page 2

The settings are per-track — each track has its own recording config.

Recording Setup page 1

KNOB	PARAM	FUNCTION
A	SRC	Source: AB, CD, A, B, C, D, MAIN, CUE, neighboring track
B	INAB	Input gain for AB pair
C	INCD	Input gain for CD pair
D	RLEN	Recording length in steps (1–256, or INF)
E	FTSY	Pre-trigger memory (some history before record start)
F	RTRIG	Auto-retrigger behavior

Recording Setup page 2

KNOB	PARAM	FUNCTION
A	QREC	Quantise recording start (off, 1/16 to bar)
B	QPL	Quantise playback start
C	SRC3	Internal source: which other track to capture
D	LFO	LFO routing on input
E	LOOP	Loop the recording (replaces older content as it fills)
F	FREE	Free-record mode (manual stop)

Memory config

The recorder memory pool is split into eight buffers. Memory settings (PROJECT → MEMORY CONFIG):

- **Recorder buffer length** — total memory, in seconds. Distributed equally across the 8 buffers.
- **Mono / stereo** — mono buffers double their recordable length
- **16-bit / 24-bit** — 16-bit doubles the length compared to 24-bit

The default memory config gives roughly 30 seconds per buffer at 16-bit stereo. Bumping up to 60+ seconds requires either reducing Flex memory or going mono/16-bit.

Triggering recording

Several ways to start recording:

- **REC AB** — record AB pair into the active track's buffer (record-quick mode), or hold a **TRACK** button to record into that specific track
- A record-trig in the sequencer — placed on a step like a normal trig, but on a "record track" view
- External MIDI message (CC remote-trigger of recording)

Quantised recording

With QREC set to a non-zero value, the recorder waits until the next quantise boundary before actually starting. Press REC AB on beat 2.5; with QREC = 1/4 bar, recording begins at beat 3.

Useful for: capturing aligned-to-beat material live, where you can't time button presses precisely. The recorder does the quantising for you.

Length presets vs free record

RLEN sets a fixed length in steps. The recorder captures exactly that much, then stops. For a 16-step pattern at 1/16 time scale, RLEN = 16 captures one bar.

FREE mode disables RLEN; you stop recording manually. The recorder captures until you press the same trigger again, or until the buffer is full. Useful when you don't know the length in advance.

NOTE · THE BUFFER IS VOLATILE

Recorder buffers are in RAM. They're not saved on power-off, and they're not saved with the project unless you explicitly save them via "Save Recording" (PROJECT → CARD TOOLS). For live performance this is fine — buffers regenerate as you sample. For anything you want to keep, save explicitly.

Playing back recordings

Recorder buffers are accessible as samples. On a Flex or Static machine, you can assign a recorder buffer as the slot source (via the Setup page). Recording on T1 and playing the result back through a Flex machine on T1 means T1 captures and replays in the same track — the basis for live looping.

Pickup machines (chapter 15) wrap this entire workflow into a single machine type. For workflows where you want explicit control over capture timing and slot assignment, the manual recorder setup gives finer control.

PART VII · SAMPLING & THE AUDIO EDITOR

Chapter 20

Audio editor

The Audio Editor is where you trim, loop, slice, and analyse samples. Two main pages: TRIM for boundary editing and SLICE for slice-grid creation.

Accessing the editor

From the Sample Manager (PROJECT → SAMPLE MANAGER), select a sample and press **YES**. The editor opens with the sample's waveform displayed on the LCD.

Or from a track: hold **FUNCTION** + **BANK** (EDIT) with the active track selected and a Flex/Static machine loaded. This opens the editor for the track's current sample.

TRIM page

TRIM lets you set the sample's start and end points (the bounds of playback) and loop points (for sustained playback).

Knob	Function
A	TRIM IN — start point of the sample
B	TRIM OUT — end point of the sample
C	LOOP IN — loop start point
D	LOOP OUT — loop end point
E	Zoom level
F	Cursor position (for fine-tuning)

Why trim points matter

Trim points are saved with the slot list, not with the sample file itself. So one audio file can have multiple slots pointing to it with different trim/loop settings. The audio file is shared; the playback bounds are slot-specific.

Practical use: a single 30-second loop file can be referenced by 16 different Flex slots, each trimmed to a different 2-second section. One file, 16 different one-bar loops accessible per slot.

Auto-trim

The TRIM page menu offers auto-trim functions:

- **Auto trim** — find silence at start/end and trim to non-silent boundaries
- **Auto loop** — find a clean loop point in the sample (zero-crossings, period analysis)
- **Normalize** — boost the sample's level to maximum without clipping

SLICE page

Slicing divides a sample into up to 64 named regions, each individually addressable as a "slice number" via the STRT parameter (chapter 16) or via SLICES trig mode (chapter 11).

Creating slices

From the SLICE page menu:

- **Auto-slice (grid)** — divide the sample into N equal regions (4, 8, 16, 32, 64). Most common for drum loops.
- **Auto-slice (transients)** — analyse the audio and place slice boundaries at detected transients. Threshold adjustable.
- **Manual slice** — place slice points by ear with the cursor

Editing slices

- Adjust slice boundaries with the cursor + knob A
- Each slice's individual length can be tweaked
- Delete unwanted slices or merge adjacent ones
- Save the slice grid back to the slot

Playing slices

Once sliced, a sample's slices can be played by:

- SLICES trig mode — each trig key plays a different slice
- STRT p-locks — set per step in TRACKS mode for sequenced slicing
- LFO-modulated STRT — LFO cycles through slice numbers for random or rhythmic slicing

Sample chain workflow

A "sample chain" is multiple short samples concatenated into one file, then sliced. Useful for getting more sounds into a single track with one slot.

Build a chain externally (in a DAW) — one drum hit per equal time-segment, e.g. eight 0.5-second segments forming a 4-second file. Import the chain into a Flex slot. Auto-slice 8 ways. Now each trig in SLICES mode plays a different drum hit, all from one slot, one sample.

Resampling

Resampling = recording the OT's own output back into a recorder buffer, then loading that buffer as a new sample. This is how you "freeze" a complex performance into a single sample, freeing up tracks.

Steps:

1. Set up a track with a Flex machine and the recorder buffer of another track as its source (via SRC3 setting in Recording Setup)
2. Configure recording with QREC for clean alignment
3. Trigger recording while the source is playing
4. Save the resulting buffer to the Audio Pool
5. Load the saved sample as a new Flex slot — replacing the original tracks

Resampling is essential for live performance: a complex four- track drum arrangement can be flattened to one Flex slot, freeing three tracks for other use.

TIP · ZERO-CROSSING FOR CLEAN LOOPS

Loop points work best at zero-crossings — points where the waveform crosses the centre line. The OT's loop-finder tries to identify these automatically, but for tricky material you may need to manually nudge to a zero-crossing. Click + cursor near the suspected point; zoom in; find the cleanest crossing within a few samples. The result is artifact-free looping.

PART VIII · SCENES, PARTS, CROSSFADER

Chapter 21

Scenes & the crossfader

The Octatrack's signature performance feature. Scenes are parameter snapshots; the crossfader morphs between two of them in real time. This is what makes the OT a "performance sampler" and not just a sequencer.

Scenes — what they are

A scene is a snapshot of parameter values across all eight tracks. Specifically, it stores any parameter that has been scene-locked — meaning explicitly assigned to that scene with a particular value. Parameters that are not scene-locked don't appear in the scene; they remain controlled by the part's base values and pattern p-locks.

Each part has 16 scenes, numbered 1–16. The crossfader assigns one scene to its A end and one to its B end. Moving the fader morphs every scene-locked parameter between its A value and its B value.

The fader is a parameter morph, not an audio gate

Repeating from chapter 8: the crossfader does not gate audio. It interpolates parameter values. If you want it to fade a track in or out, you scene-lock the track's level — at zero in scene A and at maximum in scene B. The fader then becomes a level interpolator for that track.

The implication: every parameter that supports scene-locking can be morphed by the fader. Pitch, FX cutoff, sample slot, scene locks themselves — anything. This is why the crossfader is more than a DJ-style mixer fader.

Setting a scene lock

1. Hold **SCENE A** (or **SCENE B**) and press a trig key to select which scene to assign to that fader end.
2. Make sure the fader is fully at the chosen end (A or B).
3. Hold **SCENE A** (or B) again and turn a knob on any parameter page. The knob's value is recorded into that scene.
4. Release. The parameter is now scene-locked.

The locked parameter shows a small "X" indicator on the LCD when the scene is active. Move the fader: the parameter follows the interpolation between A and B.

What can be scene-locked

Almost every parameter on the OT supports scene-locking:

- All PLAYBACK parameters (pitch, slot, start, length, rate)
- All AMP parameters (envelope, volume, balance, XVOL)
- All FX1 / FX2 parameters
- LFO depths and destinations
- Track mute states (binary scene-lock — track on at A, off at B)

Multi-track scenes are powerful: scene 1 might lock T1 mute on, T2 cutoff at 50, T3 reverb mix at 100; scene 2 locks T1 mute off, T2 cutoff at 127, T3 reverb mix at 0. Sliding the fader morphs all three simultaneously.

SCENE A vs SCENE B (the buttons)

The Scene A / Scene B buttons at the bottom-right are assigners. They don't trigger scenes — they choose which scene the corresponding fader end maps to. The actual morph happens via the fader.

Held alone, each turns the trig row into a 16-scene selector for its fader end. Press a trig to assign that scene to that end. With **FUNCTION** they become MUTE buttons — instantly silencing the assigned scene without moving the fader.

Crossfader assignments and patterns

Scene assignments are part-level. Switching parts changes which scenes are mapped. Switching patterns within the same part preserves the scene assignment but the patterns play different sequencer content — meaning your scene-controlled morph stays the same even as the underlying pattern changes.

Recipe — basic build/drop

RECIPE — ENERGY CURVE VIA CROSSFADER

Setup:

- Scene A: T1 (drums) muted, T2 (bass) cutoff at 30, FX2 reverb mix at 0, T6 (atmosphere) volume at 100

- Scene B: T1 (drums) unmuted, T2 (bass) cutoff at 127, FX2 reverb mix at 60, T6 (atmosphere) volume at 0

Move the fader from A to B over 16 bars. The track builds: drums fade in, bass opens up, reverb increases, atmosphere drops out. One fader gesture, full energy curve.

RECIPE — A/B VARIATION

Scene A is the "main" mix. Scene B is the "variation" mix — different drum slot, different bass pitch, different FX. Move the fader to instantly transform the pattern. Useful for live A/B section switches without changing patterns.

The classic crossfader transition

A widely-used technique: prepare two patterns that share a part. Pattern A's scene 1 is the current state; pattern B's scene 1 is the destination state. As you switch from A to B (chained pattern), the fader can slide simultaneously to interpolate. Result: smooth tempo-locked transitions between patterns that don't sound like sudden cuts.

HIDDEN · SCENE 17 — THE "CURRENT" SCENE

Scenes 1–16 are user-assignable. There's an implicit "scene 17" — the current state of all parameters when no scene is active. Pressing FUNCTION + SCENE A clears the A assignment and the fader becomes A=current/B=current — meaning the fader has no effect. Useful for temporarily disabling crossfader morphing without un-assigning your scenes.

Parts and scene scope

Each part has its own 16 scenes. Switching parts (within a bank, via the Part menu) loads a different set of scenes. This means a bank's four parts can each have completely different crossfader-driven morphs — switch parts, and your fader gesture means something different.

Carefully designed parts + scenes + patterns is how OT sets are built. A live performer might have 16 patterns × 4 parts × 16 scenes = 1024 distinct addressable musical states per bank. With 16 banks per project, the combinatorial space is enormous.

PART IX · MIDI

Chapter 22

MIDI tracks

Eight MIDI tracks running in parallel with the audio tracks. The OT can sequence external gear with the same trig + p-lock paradigm — including LFOs, scenes, and conditional trigs.

Activating MIDI mode

Press the **MIDI** button (callout 11). The button's LED lights, and the trig row, parameter pages, and encoders now address MIDI tracks instead of audio tracks. Press again to return to audio.

The eight MIDI tracks are independent of the eight audio tracks. They share the trig keys but have their own parts, patterns, parameters, and scenes.

Per-MIDI-track configuration

On the MIDI Setup page (**FUNCTION** + **PLAYBACK** while in MIDI mode):

PARAM	FUNCTION
CHAN	MIDI channel 1–16
OUT	Output port (MIDI Out, USB-MIDI not supported, internal channel routing)
BANK	Program/Bank Select
PROG	Program Change
NOTE	Base note (MIDI note number)
VEL	Default velocity
LEN	Default note length

The five MIDI parameter pages

In MIDI mode, the parameter row buttons map to:

- **NOTE** — the playback page for MIDI: note, velocity, length, channel-related params
- **ARP** — arpeggiator settings

- **LFO** — same three-LFO system as audio, targets MIDI parameters
- **CTRL 1** — first user-assignable CC page (8 CC targets)
- **CTRL 2** — second user-assignable CC page (8 CC targets)

CTRL 1 and CTRL 2 each let you assign 8 CC numbers to the encoders — 16 CCs total per MIDI track, each with full p-lock and LFO capability. This makes the OT a deeply capable MIDI controller, not just a sequencer.

The arpeggiator

The ARP page activates a per-track arpeggiator. Settings:

- Mode (up, down, alternate, random, polyphonic)
- Speed (multiplier of project tempo)
- Octave range
- Length (how many cycles before stopping)
- Probability (each arp note can have a percentage chance)

The arpeggiator is rare in performance samplers and is a strong point of the OT's MIDI implementation. Combined with note p-locks you can sequence arps that change pattern and rate per step.

MIDI sequencing examples

RECIPE — SEQUENCE EXTERNAL SYNTH

Set MIDI track 1's CHAN to match the synth's receive channel. Place trigs on the trig row. Each trig fires a note at the base pitch (NOTE param). P-lock pitch per step for a melodic sequence. The synth plays the OT's notes — you've turned the OT into an external sequencer with full Octatrack-style p-lock capabilities.

RECIPE — CC MODULATION ALONGSIDE NOTES

On the same MIDI track, configure CTRL 1 with the synth's filter CC. P-lock the CC per step alongside note p-locks. Now your sequenced notes carry filter modulation per step — no need for the synth to handle the modulation internally.

MIDI receive

The OT also receives MIDI on the IN port. Common uses:

- External clock (PROJECT → SYNC SOURCE = MIDI)
- Note-triggering audio tracks (MIDI note ON triggers a sample playback)
- CC remote control of OT parameters (assignable in PROJECT → MIDI MAP)

The MIDI MAP lets you assign external CCs to OT parameters (filter cutoff, FX values, scene morphs, etc.). Combined with an external controller (or Push, or another sequencer) the OT becomes deeply remote-controllable.

TurboMIDI

Between two Elektron devices, the MIDI cables negotiate a higher baud rate (TurboMIDI), reducing latency on dense CC streams. This is automatic — connect Elektron to Elektron, get TurboMIDI. With non-Elektron gear, falls back to standard MIDI baud (no impact).

Useful in practice for sequencing other Elektron units: Digitone, Analog Rytm, Digitakt — all benefit from TurboMIDI when sequenced from the OT.

PART IX · MIDI

Chapter 23

MIDI sync & clocking

Configuring the Octatrack as MIDI master, slave, or in daisy-chained setups with multiple devices.

Sync modes

PROJECT → SYNC SOURCE has three options:

- **INT** — internal clock. The OT's tempo is master.
- **MIDI** — slave to incoming MIDI clock on the IN port.
- **USB** — slave to USB MIDI (rare; requires host software supporting USB MIDI clock).

The OT as master

Default mode. The OT generates clock and sends it on the OUT port. Connected slaves (synths, drum machines, other Elektron units) follow the OT's tempo and transport.

To send clock: PROJECT → MIDI → SYNC → CLOCK SEND = ON. The OT transmits 24 PPQ MIDI clock continuously when running.

The OT also sends MIDI Start, Stop, and Continue messages aligned with its transport. Most slaves respect these.

The OT as slave

Set SYNC SOURCE = MIDI. The OT's transport now follows incoming MIDI clock. Press PLAY on the master device; the OT starts. Stop on master; OT stops.

The OT's internal tempo display shows the received tempo. Tempo changes on the master propagate immediately.

Caveat: when slaved, the OT's tempo knob is disabled. To fine-tune tempo, do it on the master.

Daisy-chaining

A daisy chain uses MIDI THRU to forward incoming clock from one device to the next. Master → slave 1 (IN, THRU) → slave 2 (IN, THRU) → ...

The OT's THRU port forwards exactly what arrives at IN — no re-clocking, no re-buffering. So long as the OT is in slave mode, its THRU is functionally a passthrough.

Latency considerations

MIDI clock has finite resolution — 24 PPQ at MIDI's standard baud introduces a jitter floor of ~1 ms. For most performance applications this is inaudible. For tight synchronisation (parallel drum machines hitting the same beat) you may want TurboMIDI between two Elektron devices, which reduces clock jitter.

On non-Elektron daisy chains, expect a few milliseconds of cumulative delay across multiple THRU stages. Splitter boxes (re-clocking distribution amplifiers) help on long chains.

Project-wide MIDI settings

Beyond sync source, several MIDI settings live at the project level (PROJECT → MIDI):

- **CLOCK SEND** — transmit clock
- **CLOCK RECV** — receive clock
- **TRANSPORT SEND** — transmit Start/Stop/Continue
- **TRANSPORT RECV** — receive transport messages
- **PROGRAM CHANGE SEND/RECV** — pattern changes as MIDI Program Change
- **CC SEND** — send CC for OT parameters (rare; for external monitoring or recording)

Using OT pattern changes as PC

With PROGRAM CHANGE SEND = ON, switching patterns on the OT sends a MIDI PC message corresponding to the pattern number. Slaves that listen for PC can switch their own patterns in sync.

Practical use: OT pattern A1 sends PC 0; the connected Digitone switches to its pattern 0. OT to A2 sends PC 1; Digitone switches to 1. With careful pattern numbering, both devices can step through aligned arrangements.

NOTE · USB DOES NOT CARRY AUDIO OR MIDI CLOCK

The Octatrack's USB port is for SysEx (firmware updates, project backup) and disk-mode access only. There is no USB MIDI, no USB audio, no Overbridge — even though many of Elektron's other products support these. The OT MK1 was developed before USB MIDI/audio became standard on Elektron's lineup. Don't expect it.

PART X · THE ARRANGER

Chapter 24

The arranger

The Octatrack's song mode. Chains patterns into long-form arrangements with per-row tempo, length, and offset overrides. Eight arrangements per project.

What an arrangement is

An arrangement is a list of rows. Each row plays a specific pattern for a specified duration before advancing to the next row. With careful row design, you can build full-length songs out of sequenced patterns — verse, chorus, bridge, drop, outro — without manually changing patterns during playback.

A project holds 8 arrangements, accessible via **FUNCTION** + **PATTERN**. Each arrangement can have up to 256 rows.

Row anatomy

Each row specifies:

FIELD	FUNCTION
Pattern	Which pattern (e.g. A01, B05) to play
Length	How many bars (or pattern repeats) to stay on this row
Offset	Skip the first N steps of the pattern
BPM	Override project tempo for this row
Mute	Mute specific tracks for this row
Transpose	Per-row pitch shift in semitones
Scene	Force scene assignments for this row
Trig	Optional trigger conditions before advancing

Building an arrangement

1. Open the arranger page (**FUNCTION** + **PATTERN**)
2. Use UP/DOWN to navigate row by row; LEFT/RIGHT to switch between fields within a row

3. Knob A selects pattern; B sets length; etc.
4. Add rows as needed by stepping past the last row
5. Save with **FUNCTION** + **YES**

Activate arrangement playback: from the arrangement page, press **PLAY**. The OT plays through rows in sequence. To jump to a specific row during playback, navigate to it and press **YES**.

Per-row overrides

Tempo

The BPM field overrides the project tempo for the duration of that row. Useful for tempo modulation across a song — gradually accelerating drum-and-bass build-ups, or slow-down outros. Setting BPM = 0 inherits from the project.

Mute

The Mute field lets you specify which tracks are muted during the row. Set up base patterns with everything playing, then mute elements per row to create song structure without rewriting patterns.

Transpose

Per-row pitch shift. The OT's notion of "musical key" is at the arrangement row level. Shift +5 semitones for a key change at the chorus, -3 for a darker bridge.

Loops within arrangements

A row can be set to LOOP — it stays active until something triggers it to advance. Useful for live performance where you want a section to vamp until you decide to move on. Trigger advance via the trig keys or via MIDI.

Multiple arrangements per project

With 8 arrangements per project, you can store entire setlists. One arrangement per song; switch arrangements between songs in a set. The 8-arrangement limit is generous for most use cases.

Arranger vs live pattern switching

Arranger is one workflow; manual pattern switching is the other. Most performers use both: arrangements for structured material, manual switching for improvisation. The OT supports interrupt-the- arrangement workflow where you can stop the current row and switch to manual control mid-song.

TIP · ROW-LEVEL SCENES

The Scene field lets each row force the crossfader to specific scene assignments. Combined with Mute and Transpose, this means a single arrangement row carries a complete musical context — not just "play pattern A" but "play A with these mutes, this transpose, this scene assignment". An arrangement of 16 rows is effectively a 16-state composition machine.

PART XI · PERFORMANCE RECIPES

Chapter 25

Performance recipes

Workflow patterns for getting useful results out of the Octatrack quickly. Each recipe is a starting framework — adapt to your context.

Recipe — first 90 minutes

GET SOUND OUT OF THE OT, FAST

Goal: from boot to a working four-bar sketch in under 90 minutes.

1. Boot the OT. Verify CF card is installed and formatted.
2. Create a new project: PROJECT → NEW. Name it.
3. Drop a few drum samples (kick, snare, hat) into the Audio Pool via the Sample Manager. Assign each to a Flex slot.
4. On T1, load a Flex machine. Assign the kick slot.
5. Place trigs on steps 1, 5, 9, 13. You have a four-on-the-floor kick.
6. On T2, Flex machine, assign snare. Trigs on 5 and 13.
7. On T3, Flex machine, assign hi-hat. Trigs on 3, 7, 11, 15 (or 16 trigs with conditional probability).
8. Press PLAY. You have a beat.
9. Spend the next 80 minutes adjusting volumes, pitches, and adding p-locks. Don't worry about perfection.

The point is to get audio happening fast and iterate from there. The OT rewards iteration.

Recipe — beat slicing

TURN A DRUM LOOP INTO 16 PLAYABLE HITS

1. Load a 1-bar drum loop into a Flex slot.

2. Open the audio editor (chapter 20). Go to the SLICE page.
 3. Auto-slice with grid = 16. The loop is now divided into 16 equal slices.
 4. Save. Return to the track.
 5. Switch to SLICES trig mode (FUNCTION + UP/DOWN).
 6. Each trig key now plays a different slice. Build new patterns by hitting trigs in any order.
 7. Switch back to TRACKS mode. Place trigs and p-lock the STRT (slice number) parameter to choose which slices fire on which steps.
- Two minutes of setup yields a slice-able drum kit playable from any pattern.

Recipe — DJ-style transition

SMOOTH PATTERN TRANSITION VIA THE CROSSFADER

1. Pattern A: your current section.
2. Pattern B (in same part): your destination section. Same tempo.
3. Configure scene A (fader fully left): all tracks at full volume, all FX at base settings.
4. Configure scene B (fader fully right): T1 (kick) muted, T2 (bass) cutoff at 30, T3 (snare) volume at 0, FX1 reverb mix at 100.
5. While pattern A plays, slide fader from A to B over 4 bars. Pattern A "filters out" and reverbs up.
6. At the end of the slide, switch to pattern B. The crossfader is now at B end of pattern B's scene mapping.
7. Slide back to A end over 4 bars. Pattern B "fades in" with full energy.

The transition reads as a 16-bar build-and-drop without ever manually crossfading two tracks.

Recipe — live looping with Pickup

ONE-TAKE LOOP PERFORMANCE

1. T1 = Pickup (Master), source = Input AB, length = 4 bars.
2. T2 = Pickup (Slave), source = Input AB.
3. T3 = Flex playback (drums) — loop or pattern.
4. Plug guitar/synth into Input A.
5. Place a one-shot trig on T1 step 1.

6. Press PLAY. Drums start. T1 starts recording at step 1.
7. Play 4 bars of guitar. T1 captures, then loops.
8. Place a one-shot trig on T2 step 1 of the next pattern cycle.
9. Play 4 bars of an overdub layer (different chord / harmony). T2 captures, loops.
10. You now have drums + 2 layers of looping. Apply scenes for mute/unmute on the loops; build energy curves.

Recipe — generative drum pattern

CONDITIONAL TRIGS + LFO MODULATION = PATTERN THAT MUTATES

1. Build a base drum pattern: kick on 1/5/9/13, snare on 5/13, hat on every step.
2. Add 8 more "ghost" trigs across the pattern. Set each to condition 50% (probability).
3. Add 4 more "fill" trigs. Set each to condition FILL.
4. On the snare track, configure LFO 1: WAVE = random, DEST = STRT, DEPTH = ± 20 , TRIG mode = TRIG. Each snare hit plays from a random offset within the sample.
5. On the hi-hat track, configure LFO 2: WAVE = sine, DEST = AMP VOL, DEPTH = ± 10 , MULT = 4 (one cycle per bar). The hat volume gently breathes.
6. Press PLAY. The pattern is structurally identical every bar but sonically different — the 50% trigs come and go, the snare sample-start jumps around, the hat volume breathes.
7. Hit FUNCTION+YES to drop a fill momentarily.

Recipe — hub workflow (OT + external gear)

OT AS THE CENTRAL BRAIN OF A SMALL LIVE SETUP

1. OT is master. Configure CLOCK SEND = ON, TRANSPORT SEND = ON.
2. Connect OT MIDI OUT → external synth (e.g. Digitone) MIDI IN.
3. Connect synth audio out → OT Input AB.
4. On the OT, set up a MIDI track sequencing the synth (chapter 22). P-lock notes per step.
5. Set up an OT audio track with a Thru machine on Input AB — the synth's audio runs through the OT's FX.
6. The OT now sequences the synth AND processes its audio. Apply scenes to morph FX on the synth's audio. Use the OT's recorder to capture portions of the synth's output as samples.

Result: one OT centralises sequencing, audio routing, FX processing, and live capture for an entire small rig.

Recipe — randomisation as composition tool

USE RANDOMISATION TO ESCAPE "BLANK PATTERN PARALYSIS"

1. Start with an empty pattern.
2. FUNCTION + RANDOM (the trig key labelled RANDOM in conditions) populates the pattern with random trigs.
3. Listen for what works. Keep the trigs you like; remove the rest.
4. Random-LFO on the SLOT parameter cycles through samples per step — yielding chaotic but surprisingly musical beats.
5. Use 50% conditional trigs for organic-feeling variation.
6. Iterate. Randomisation is a starting point; your taste is the editor.

Recipe — the dub send

THROW ANY SOUND INTO DELAY/REVERB AT ANY MOMENT

1. T8 = Master machine with FX1 = Delay, FX2 = Reverb.
 2. Configure each track's CUE level: 0 by default.
 3. Live performance: hold CUE + a TRACK button to send that track's audio to the CUE bus, which (via the Master machine's FX configuration) routes through delay and reverb.
 4. Releasing the CUE+TRACK combo cuts the send. The delay/reverb tails decay naturally.
- Effectively a one-button "dub throw" on any track at any time.

PART XII · REFERENCE APPENDICES

Appendix A

Button combo encyclopedia

Every documented and hidden key combination on the Octatrack MK1, organised by primary key. Print-friendly.

Format

Each combo is shown as **FUNCTION** + **KEY**. Some combos require multiple steps (hold A, then press B). "FN" is shorthand for FUNCTION.

Transport

COMBO	ACTION
PLAY	Play / pause sequencer
STOP	Stop sequencer
STOP + STOP	Stop and rewind to step 1
FN + STOP	Stop all Pickup tracks immediately
REC + PLAY	Live Record (unquantised)
FN + REC + PLAY	Live Record (quantised)
REC alone (in record mode)	Exit Live Record without stopping

Trigs and editing

COMBO	ACTION
TRIG	Toggle trig on/off
TRIG hold + knob	Set parameter lock for that step
TRIG hold + LEFT/RIGHT	Set microtiming
TRIG hold + LEVEL knob	Set conditional trig
TRIG hold + NO	Clear all locks on that step
TRIG hold + knob press	Clear that parameter's lock on that step
FN + TRIG	Trigless lock (parameter changes without re-trigger)
YES + TRIG	Preview step (with locks), to MAIN
CUE + TRIG	Preview step (with locks), to CUE
FN + NO (in Live Record)	Erase trigs as playhead passes

Track selection

COMBO	ACTION
T1-T8	Select that track
T1-T8 hold	Mute that track (momentary)
FN + T1-T8	Toggle track mute
CUE + T1-T8	Toggle track CUE send
Two T buttons together	Solo (mute everything else)

Trig modes

COMBO	ACTION
FN + UP/DOWN	Cycle through trig modes (TRACKS / CHROMATIC / SLICES / SLOTS / QUICK MUTE / DELAY CONTROL)
UP/DOWN (in CHROMATIC)	Octave shift
LEFT/RIGHT (in SLICES)	Page through slice ranges

Patterns and banks

COMBO	ACTION
PATTERN + TRIG 1-16	Switch to that pattern within the bank
BANK + TRIG 1-16	Switch to that bank (A-P)
FN + PATTERN	Open arranger
FN + BANK	Edit pattern (audio editor for current track)
FN + YES (on pattern page)	Save pattern

Parts and scenes

COMBO	ACTION
SCENE A + TRIG	Assign that scene number to fader's A end
SCENE B + TRIG	Assign that scene number to fader's B end
SCENE A + knob	Set scene-locked value for active parameter
FN + SCENE A	Mute scene A's effect (clear A assignment temporarily)
FN + YES (on part page)	Save part
MIDI hold (PART)	Open part menu (part list, save, load, copy)

Sample preview and sampling

COMBO	ACTION
REC AB	Quick-record from AB into active track's recorder
REC CD	Quick-record from CD into active track's recorder
FN + REC AB	Recording Setup page 1
FN + REC CD	Recording Setup page 2
REC AB hold + T	Record into specified track's buffer

Fill mode

COMBO	ACTION
FN + YES	Toggle fill mode
FN + YES (hold)	Momentary fill (release to deactivate)

Save / load / copy

COMBO	ACTION
FN + YES	Save current item (pattern / part / project depending on context)
FN + NO	Reload (discard changes since last save)
COPY + select	Copy selected (track / pattern / part / scene)
PASTE + target	Paste to target
CLEAR + target	Clear selected

Hidden combos

COMBO	HIDDEN BEHAVIOUR
Hold TRIG 1-4 at boot	Early Startup Menu (test, OS upgrade, file system tools)
FN + LFO	Open LFO designer (custom waveforms)
FN + EFFECT 1	FX1 setup screen
FN + EFFECT 2	FX2 setup screen
FN + SCALE SETUP	Pattern length / time scale settings
FN + MIDI	MIDI Part / Pickup-specific settings
FN + MIXER	Project page
FN + PLAYBACK	Machine Setup page
FN + AMP	(reserved / context-dependent)

Cheat sheet — top 10 most-used

1. **TRIG** hold + knob → p-lock
2. **FN** + **TRIG** → trigless lock
3. **YES** + **TRIG** → preview step
4. **REC** + **PLAY** → Live Record
5. **FN** + UP/DOWN → cycle trig modes
6. **SCENE A** + knob → scene-lock parameter
7. **FN** + **YES** → save current item
8. **FN** + **NO** → reload
9. **BANK** + **TRIG** → switch bank
10. **PATTERN** + **TRIG** → switch pattern

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Appendix B

Troubleshooting

Common problems and their fixes. Plus the early startup menu — the OT's diagnostic and recovery shell, accessed by holding trig keys at boot.

"My changes disappeared"

By far the most common problem. Almost always: an unsaved part.

- Did you save the part? FUNCTION + YES on the part page.
- Did you save the pattern? FUNCTION + YES on the pattern page.
- Did you save the project? PROJECT → SAVE.

Patterns, parts, and projects each have their own save state. All three need committing to disk before power-off, or the changes are lost. The OT does not auto-save.

"My CF card is corrupted"

Symptoms: project won't load, samples missing, weird errors at boot. Usually caused by power-cycling during a write operation.

Steps:

1. Power off the OT cleanly (don't yank power)
2. Remove the CF card and insert it into a card reader on a computer
3. Run the OS-level disk repair (chkdsk on Windows, Disk Utility on macOS, fsck on Linux)
4. If repair succeeds, reinsert and reboot the OT
5. If repair fails, reformat (FAT32) and restore from backup

"I can't get sound out of a Flex track"

Diagnostic:

1. Is a sample assigned? Check the SLOT parameter.
2. Is the track muted? Check track LED on the trig row.
3. Is the AMP VOL > 0?

4. Is the AMP envelope set sensibly? (ATK = 0, HOLD > 0, REL > 0)
5. Are there trigs on the pattern?
6. Is the track routed to MAIN? (Mixer page)
7. Is the FX2 reverb mix at 0 with reverb dry-only? Sometimes you've cranked dry/wet to wet-only.
8. Is the crossfader scene-locked to mute the track?

"My Pickup track won't start recording"

- Is the trig a one-shot (YES + TRIG)? Plain trigs don't trigger Pickup state changes.
- Is the source set correctly? Check SETUP → SRC.
- Is there an input signal? Check the AB / CD level meters at the top.
- Is RTRIG enabled? Auto-retrigger sometimes interferes.
- Is the buffer already full from a previous capture? Clear with FUNCTION + the one-shot trig.

"Crossfader doesn't do anything"

- Are scenes assigned to A and B? Check SCENE A / SCENE B button LEDs.
- Are any parameters scene-locked? If neither scene has any locked parameters, the fader has nothing to morph.
- Are A and B assigned to the same scene? They'd produce identical output across the fader range.
- Is XVOL the parameter you locked, but VOL is at 0? See chapter 16's XVOL trap.

"Audio is glitchy / dropouts"

- Check Memory Config — too many Static streams from a slow card may cause dropouts. Convert some to Flex.
- CF card speed: slow cards (sub 120x) struggle with multiple Static tracks. Fast cards (300x+) are recommended.
- Reformat the card if you suspect file-system fragmentation.
- Power supply: undervoltage causes intermittent issues. Use the official Elektron PSU, not a generic 12V DC.

"Tempo drifts when slaved"

- Long MIDI THRU chains accumulate jitter. Use a re-clocking splitter for chains over 3 devices.
- Some master devices send unstable clock when their internal sequencers are doing other work. Check by slaving the OT to a known-good clock source (e.g. a different drum machine).
- Two Elektron devices benefit from TurboMIDI for tighter sync. Verify both are connected by a single MIDI cable directly.

The Early Startup Menu

Hold **TRIG 1**, **TRIG 2**, **TRIG 3**, or **TRIG 4** while powering on the OT. Each opens a different diagnostic / recovery shell.

TRIG 1 — Test mode

Hardware test menu. Tests the LCD, all keys, all knobs, MIDI ports, audio I/O, CF card. Useful when diagnosing physical failures (a dead key, a noisy knob, a misbehaving input). Each test cycles through the relevant hardware; press keys / turn knobs / etc., and the screen confirms whether the OT detects them.

TRIG 2 — OS upgrade

Boots into a minimal mode that can read OS .syx files from the CF card. Place the firmware file on the card root, hold TRIG 2 at boot, follow on-screen prompts. Used for OS upgrades when SysEx-over-USB isn't working.

TRIG 3 — File system tools

Format CF card, partition diagnostics, file-system repair from within the OT. Useful when the card is misbehaving but you don't have a card reader to hand.

TRIG 4 — Boot from CF in disk mode

Mounts the OT's CF card as a USB mass-storage device. Plug a USB cable from OT to computer, hold TRIG 4, and the card appears as a removable drive. Used for backing up samples, copying projects, bulk file management without a separate card reader.

WARNING · DISK MODE REQUIRES UNMOUNT

Always safely eject / unmount the OT from the computer's file system before disconnecting USB or rebooting. Yanking the cable mid-write can corrupt the card. The OT does not enforce this on its end — the safety check happens on the computer.

Battery replacement

The OT MK1 has an internal CR2032 battery for the real-time clock. Lifespan: 5–8 years. When low, the OT loses date/time settings between boots (project timestamps wrong, etc.). The machine still functions but RTC is unreliable.

Replacement requires opening the unit. Reasonably accessible if you're comfortable with screwdrivers; consult Elektron's service documentation for procedure. The battery is not user-serviceable in any official sense — replacing voids any remaining warranty.

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Appendix C

Glossary

Octatrack-specific terminology. Most terms appear in the official manual; some are community shorthand.

AUDIO POOL	The set-level folder containing all sample files available to projects within that set. See chapter 7.
BANK	A container holding 16 patterns and 4 parts. A project has 16 banks (A–P). Each bank's patterns share its parts. See chapter 6.
BPM	Beats per minute. The OT's tempo can be project-wide or per-pattern. Per-row override available in arrangements.
BUFFER	A recorder buffer — RAM allocated for audio capture on a track. Eight buffers, one per track. See chapter 19.
CHROMATIC MODE	Trig mode where the 16 trig keys play the active sample at different chromatic pitches. See chapter 11.
CF CARD	Compact Flash. The OT's only persistent storage medium. See chapter 6.
CONDITIONAL TRIG	A trig that fires only if a condition is met (probability, previous trig, neighbour, fill, etc.). See chapter 10.
CROSSFADER	Hardware fader that morphs parameters between Scene A and Scene B. Does not gate audio directly. See chapter 21.
CUE BUS	Secondary audio bus, separate from MAIN. Routed to the rear-panel CUE outputs. Useful for headphone pre-listen and Studio Mode. See chapter 8.
DELAY CONTROL MODE	Trig mode where each trig key momentarily activates a different delay setting. Performance-oriented. See chapter 11.
FILL MODE	Momentary mode that activates FILL-conditional trigs. See chapter 10.
FLEX	A machine type. Plays samples loaded into RAM. Supports reversal, pitch, time-stretch, slicing. See chapter 13.
FX1, FX2	Two effects slots per track. FX1 runs first, FX2 second. Catalogues differ slightly. See chapter 18.
LFO DESIGNER	Custom-waveform editor for LFOs. 16-point grid with interpolation modes. Hidden behind FUNCTION + LFO. See chapter 17.
LIVE RECORD	Real-time pattern entry mode. Activate with REC + PLAY. See chapter 12.
MASTER MACHINE	A machine type loaded only on T8. Turns T8 into a master-bus processor. See chapter 14.
MEMORY CONFIG	Project-wide RAM allocation between Flex samples and recorder buffers. See chapter 7.

MICROTIMING	Per-trig timing offset, in 1/23rd-of-a-step increments. See chapter 10.
NEIGHBOR MACHINE	A machine that reads the audio output of the previous track. Used to chain effects across tracks. See chapter 14.
ONE-SHOT TRIG	A trig that fires once, then disarms. Used by Pickup machines and for triggered events. Set with YES + TRIG.
PARAMETER LOCK (P-LOCK)	A parameter value applied to a single step, overriding the part's base value. The OT's signature feature. See chapter 9.
PART	Container for machine assignments, base parameter values, and scene assignments. Four parts per bank. See chapter 6.
PATTERN	A sequence of trigs and parameter locks. 1–64 steps. 16 patterns per bank. See chapter 6.
PICKUP MACHINE	A live-looper machine type. Records from a chosen source into a buffer, then loops. Master/slave configuration for synced multi-track loops. See chapter 15.
PROJECT	Top-level container holding 16 banks, settings, sample slots, arrangements. See chapter 6.
QUICK MUTE MODE	Trig mode where trig keys 1–8 toggle track mutes. See chapter 11.
QREC	Quantise recording. Recording start aligns to a chosen beat division. See chapter 19.
RESAMPLING	Recording the OT's own audio output (MAIN or CUE) into a recorder buffer. See chapter 20.
SCENE	A snapshot of parameter values across all tracks. 16 scenes per part. Two scenes assigned to crossfader ends for morphing. See chapter 21.
SCENE LOCK	A parameter explicitly assigned to a scene. The crossfader morphs only scene-locked parameters. See chapter 21.
SET	Top-level folder on the CF card. Holds the Audio Pool and one or more projects. See chapter 6.
SLICE	A named region within a sample, addressable as a slice number. Up to 64 slices per sample. See chapter 20.
SLICES MODE	Trig mode where each trig key plays a different slice of the active sample. See chapter 11.
SLOT (SAMPLE SLOT)	An assignment of a sample file to a numbered slot, with trim and loop points. Static slots (128) and Flex slots (128) are separate lists. See chapter 7.
SLOTS MODE	Trig mode where each trig key selects a different sample slot. See chapter 11.
STATIC	A machine type that streams samples from the CF card. RAM- light but limited in playback flexibility. See chapter 13.
THRU MACHINE	A machine that routes external audio input through the track's effects chain. See chapter 14.
TIMESTRETCH	Flex-only feature. Sample tempo and pitch decoupled. Three modes: NORM, BEAT, OFF. See chapter 13.
TRIG	

	A step in the pattern that fires the track's sound. See chapter 9.
TRIGLESS LOCK	A parameter lock that does not retrigger the sound. Set with FUNCTION + TRIG. See chapter 9.
TURBOMIDI	Higher-baud-rate MIDI between two Elektron devices. Reduces clock jitter. Automatic when both ends support it. See chapter 23.
XVOL	Crossfader-controlled volume offset. Used for fader-driven track fade-in/out via scene-locking. See chapter 16.